



Hindustan Times

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IRAN WARNS GULF STATES: TELL TRUMP TO DESIST OR WE HIT YOU HARD

TEHRAN: Iran has made a concerted diplomatic push with Gulf states, warning them explicitly that Tehran will hit their oil, power and water plants unless they cease sending Donald Trump to end US strikes on Iran and instead seek a negotiated end to the war.

Officials with knowledge of the discussions said Iranian foreign minister Seyyed Abbas Araghchi spoke with his Saudi, Turkish and Qatari counterparts, as well as Pakistan's army chief in this regard. "We're ready to retaliate, but finding a diplomatic solution is the best way to avoid wider escalation and destruction across the region," a regional diplomat said.

The Iranian warning was unequivocal: If America targeted Iran's infrastructure, they would retaliate by striking Gulf energy facilities and other regional targets, a Gulf source said. **-PTI**

NETANYAHU DIALS MODI, DISCUSSES W ASIA SITUATION

NEW DELHI: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu dialled his Indian counterpart Narendra Modi on Thursday to review bilateral relations and discuss the situation in West Asia.

"Received a phone call from Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. We reviewed progress on various aspects of the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership which continues to grow from strength-to-strength. Modi said on social media.

"We also exchanged views on the current situation in West Asia," he said without giving details. An Indian government readout said Modi and Netanyahu "reaffirmed their commitment to the partnership."

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Echo Oppn's sentiments to Amit Shah: V-P to Rijiju

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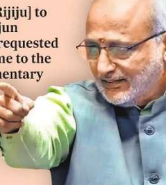
NEW DELHI: Rajya Sabha chairman CP Radhakrishnan on Thursday asked Union parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju to "echo the sentiments of the Opposition" to Union home minister Amit Shah, a rare observation that came amid mounting disruptions demanding Shah's presence over violence at sprawling student protests in Delhi last month.

Over the past two weeks, the ongoing monsoon session has been largely washed out because the Opposition demanded a statement from Shah in the House over allegations of police excesses and the use of pellet guns at the July 20 protest demanding the resignation of then education minister

RS chair's nudge

"I request you [Kiren Rijiju] to consider his [Mallikarjun Kharge's] request. He requested the home minister come to the House...As the parliamentary affairs minister, you can echo the sentiments of the Opposition to the HM (home minister)."

— CP RADHAKRISHNAN, Rajya Sabha chairman



Dharmendra Pradhan. When the Rajya Sabha reassembled at 12pm on Thursday, Congress chair and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge said, "We are asking the home min-

ister and the Prime Minister to come to the House. We request the chair to direct the home minister to come and give a statement. We are ready to discuss it." Kharge also pointed to

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FCRA BILL DEBATE ON AUG 12: MIZORAM CM

Mizoram met Union home minister Amit Shah on Thursday to discuss the concerns of church representatives about the proposed Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, saying later that he was assured that the legislation will not apply retrospectively.

Laldohma — who was accompanied by a delegation of senior Christian leaders — also said the bill was likely to be taken up for debate on August 12. **-PTI**

more stories

OUTP to hold nationwide outreach campaign **-PTI**
Rijiju reaches out to Rahul to end logjam **-PTI**

Tejpal convicted, given 10-year jail in 2013 rape case

Gerard de Souza
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PANAJI: The Bombay High Court's Goa bench on Thursday convicted former Tehelka editor Tarun Tejpal of raping a junior colleague in Goa in 2013, overturning a trial court's 2021 acquittal and sentencing him to 10 years rigorous imprisonment.

The court granted Tejpal four weeks to surrender.

A division bench of Justices Neela Gokhale and Amit Jam-sankar held that the prosecution had proved the charges beyond reasonable doubt, finding that the trial court's appreciation of evidence was "unreasonable" and "perverse." The court convicted Tejpal of rape by a person in a position of trust and authority, sexual harassment, assault with intent to disrobe, wrongful restraint and wrongful confinement under various provisions of the Indian Penal Code.

"We find that the victim has made truthful statements, and the prosecution has established the case against the respondent beyond every reasonable doubt. The Trial Court fell in error in acquitting the respondent of the charges levelled against him. The appreciation of evidence by the Trial Court is not only unreasonable but perverse. The conclusions arrived at by the Trial Court are untenable and, in the established facts and circumstances of the case, the view expressed by it is not a possible view," Justice Gokhale, who authored the judgment, said.

The High Court said the trial court had relied on "stereotypical assumptions" about how an



Tarun Tejpal

"ideal" survivor of sexual assault should behave, including drawing adverse inferences from the complainant's conduct after the alleged assaults.

"The Trial Court's findings are directly contrary to the evidence on record and thus per se perverse. The Trial Court's evaluation of the victim's testimony and evidence exhibits multiple fatal flaws, largely stemming from preconceived notions and reliance on irrelevant or inadmissible material... In doing so, the Court relied on stereotypical assumptions about how an 'ideal' victim should physically resist or emotionally react, going so far as to hold her smiling demeanour during subsequent work events against her," the court said.

The bench also observed that workplace sexual harassment has lasting consequences for women's careers and that victim-blaming and institutional resistance often isolate survivors and discourage women from pursuing professional opportunities.

"Sexual harassment at work causes significant and enduring harm to women's career paths... A widespread culture of victim

continued on -10

COMPLIANCE, MODERATION IN FOCUS AS META, GOVT HOLD TALKS

Sejal Sharma
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NEW DELHI: The Centre will continue discussions with Meta over the next three-four days on the company's content moderation policies, algorithms, and compliance mechanisms, after the temporary takedown of PM Narendra Modi's reel raised concerns, a senior IT ministry official said. **-IPS**

-IPS STAYS PLEAS IN HIGH COURTS AGAINST SAHYOGPOTAL **-PTI**

SA RECALLS ENVOY AMID ZUMA-GUPTA MEETING FURORE

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: South Africa's high commissioner to India, Anil Sooklal, has been recalled for being part of a meeting between former president Jacob Zuma and one of the Gupta brothers, who are wanted by South African authorities on charges of political corruption. **-IPS**

RBI RETAINS TATA SONS IN UPPER LAYER NBFC LIST

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India on Thursday retained Tata Sons Pvt Ltd in the upper layer of non-banking financial companies (NBFCs-UL) for FY27, leaving the Tata Group holding company subject to enhanced regulatory requirements while RBI decides on the company's application to surrender its core investment company registration. **-PTI**

-IPS, TATA DISCUSS SINGUR PROJECT **-PTI**

Gen Z grievances genuine, says RSS chief

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MUMBAI: The grievances of Gen Z are genuine and protest is also a form of dialogue, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Thursday in a mega outreach to younger people against the backdrop of student protests in Delhi last month.

Addressing around 2,000 students aged between 15 and 19, Bhagwat also spoke on unemployment, reservation, equal rights for women and those of the

LGFTQA+ community, and India's relations with its neighbouring countries.

Speaking about the recent student protests at Jantar Mantar, Bhagwat said the protesters should not be called "anti-national." "Gen Z are our own children. If they protest for an issue, how can they become anti-national? In a democracy, protest is also a form of dialogue," he said, acknowledging that improvements were needed in India's education policy for which discussions are necessary. **-PTI**

What Bhagwat said...

ON PROTESTS "Gen Z are our own children. If they protest for an issue, how can they become anti-national? Their concerns should be heard. In a democracy, protest is also a form of dialogue."

ON SAME-SEX MARRIAGE "In such (same-sex relationship) cases, we need to consider companionship which society can accept once that is achieved, there is no need to frame a law."

ON TIES WITH PAK, CHINA "China's people say for 2,000 yrs, Bharat gave them allies. Pak was Bharat's less than 100 yrs ago... Permanent hatred is not the solution... But during conflict, we are with our govt and military."



Downpour again clogs NCR



Parveen Kulkarni/HT

3 KILLED, 1 MISSING Two men died of electrocution in Gurugram and a woman was killed in a balcony collapse in Faridabad amid rains. In Delhi, a man went missing after falling into a drain.

GURUGRAM REELS Gurugram bore the brunt of Thursday's spell as inundated roads prompted a Work-From-Home advisory. Delhi reported 15 waterlogging incidents.

WET SPELL TO CONTINUE The weather office has forecast moderate to heavy rain on Friday under a yellow alert in Delhi, followed by light rain over the weekend.

CABINET CLEARS ₹23,731 CR SCHEME TO BOOST BIOGAS PRODUCTION

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Thursday approved a ₹23,731 crore national scheme to accelerate domestic Compressed Biogas (CBG) production, strengthen energy security and promote rural livelihoods by converting organic waste into clean fuel.

According to a government release, the GOBARdhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) scheme will be implemented from FY 2026-27 to 2035-36. **-PTI**

SC expands scope of subvention case probe

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday expanded the scope of the probe into the subvention scheme scam involving builder-contractor nexus by directing the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to share details of alleged proceeds of crime with the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in the 50 criminal cases being investigated by it.

With investigations in only 16 of the 50 cases completed by CBI so

far, the court passed directions for a "time-bound, expedient" probe by directing six banks and financial corporations to process prosecution sanction within two weeks against their officials found prima facie guilty in the CBI probe conducted so far. The bench headed by CJI Surya Kant was critical of the pace of investigation. "CBI has acquired the reputation of keeping the investigation pending for years and years. We expect they come out with investigations in a time-bound manner," it said. **-PTI**

SC DISMISSES LAST APPEAL AGAINST BOFORS ACQUITTAL

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday effectively brought the curtain down on the Bofors pay-off case by dismissing the only surviving appeal against the 2005 Delhi High Court judgment that quashed all criminal proceedings against the three Hinduja brothers and Swedish arms manufacturer AB Bofors. **-PTI**

FRANCE RESPONDS TO INDIA LOF FOR 114 RAFALE FIGHTERS

NEW DELHI: France has responded to a letter of request (LoR) sent by the defence ministry with a techno-commercial offer for 114 Rafale fighter jets to sharpen the IAF's combat edge, marking the next step in a deal expected to be worth \$3.35 lakh crore, officials said. **-PTI**

SUVENDU AIDE MURDER CASE: CBI CHARGE-SHEETS 11

NEW DELHI: The CBI has filed a charge sheet against 11 accused, including two BJP workers, in connection with the killing of Suvendu Adhikari's nephew, assistant Chandranath Rath, officials said on Thursday. The role of a functionary of a rival political party in the state is also under the scanner, the officials added. **-PTI**

Meaty makeover: Lettuce, tobacco engineered to produce meat protein

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NEW DELHI: Scientists have engineered lettuce and tobacco plants to produce myoglobin — the protein that gives meat its colour, taste and much of its nutritional iron — directly into their leaves, offering a potential new route to more realistic plant-based meat that doesn't rely on livestock or industrial fermentation vats.

RESEARCH OFFERS POTENTIAL ROUTE TO MORE REALISTIC PLANT-BASED MEAT THAT DOESN'T RELY ON LIVESTOCK

The study, published in *Frontiers in Plant Science* on Thursday, was led by researchers at Imperial College London

working with Cambridge-based biotech firm Kymovet Ltd, along with collaborators at the University of California and Nanchang University in China.

Myoglobin is the molecule that makes muscle red and gives meat its distinctive taste — it's abundant in the heart and skeletal muscle of all vertebrates, including the animals consumed. Most attempts to replicate it for plant-based

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NUMBER THEORY

Atrophy of the elephant:
How BSP lost Uttar Pradesh

By Nishant Ranjan

The death of Uma Shankar Singh, the lone Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) MLA in the Uttar Pradesh assembly, from Rasra in Ballia district, marks a watershed moment in Indian politics. For the first time since 1989, the Uttar Pradesh assembly will not have a BSP MLA. Come November 2026 and BSP's only Rajya Sabha MP will also retire, leaving it without representation in Parliament as well. BSP, as a political party, occupies an important political place in India's democratic history. It is the only party to have given India a Dalit chief minister (Mayawati) who completed a full term in office, and that too in India's largest state, Uttar Pradesh. BSP's contribution to Indian democracy extends beyond just its stint in government. It transformed Dalit political assertion into an independent electoral force and compelled every major political party to compete for a constituency that had long remained on the political margins. Its decline, however, has been as spectacular as its rise.



1 Technically national, the BSP was pretty much restricted to being an Uttar Pradesh party

The BSP was recognised as a national party in 1997. Its founder Kanshi Ram started his politics from Punjab. However, Uttar Pradesh is where it managed to break political ground and eventually storm the gates of power. This can be seen even in the overall state-wise break-up of BSP MLAs and MPs. Of the 696 MLAs the

party has had so far, 564 or 81% came from Uttar Pradesh alone. Of its 86 Lok Sabha MPs, 76 are from Uttar Pradesh. This underscores both the success and failure of the BSP's larger political project. It managed to win India's largest state but could not really find traction for its larger ideology outside it.

State-wise number of all BSP MPs and MLAs since the party's inception

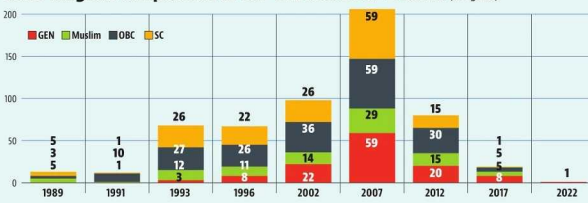


2 BSP's Uttar Pradesh success came on account of pragmatism rather than radical politics

The BSP entered the Uttar Pradesh assembly for the first time in 1989, winning 13 seats with a vote share of 9.4%. Over the next two decades, the party steadily expanded its electoral base. Between 1993 and 2002, Mayawati served three terms as chief minister through coalition arrangements with the Samajwadi Party (SP) and later the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The party reached its electoral high point in 2007 when it secured an absolute majority, winning 206 seats.

51.1% of the assembly, with a vote share of 30.4%. Mayawati became the first and only Dalit chief minister in Uttar Pradesh to complete a full five-year term. The BSP's 2007 victory, and its aftermath, however, was rooted in a kind of social engineering which tried to aggressively woo the non-Dalit, including upper caste Hindus (Singh himself was one, a Rajput). This is best seen in the social composition of its MLAs in Uttar Pradesh leading up to 2007.

Socio-religious composition of BSP MLAs in Uttar Pradesh (in figures)

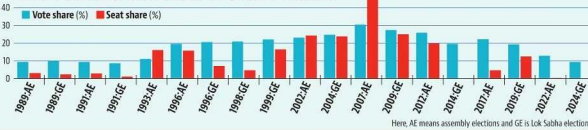


3 The BJP's rise in 2014 has almost destroyed the BSP

In the 2014 Lok Sabha elections, the BSP failed to open its vote share in Uttar Pradesh despite polling close to a 20% vote share. The 2017 assembly elections provided an illusion that the BSP was still in the fray, with both the BSP and the SP polling about a 22% vote share and finishing far behind the BJP which won a landslide with 312 MLAs in the assembly of 403. However, their moment of reckoning came in the 2019 national elections, when despite the SP and BSP burying historical hatches and coming together, the BJP polled close to 50% of the

vote share in Uttar Pradesh and won 62 seats. Within months of the results, Mayawati announced a parting of ways with the SP and the BSP contested the 2022 and 2024 elections on its own in Uttar Pradesh. The beneficiary of this process seems to have been the SP, which has added to its vote share in both these elections and even managed to finish ahead of the BJP in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. BSP's vote share is now in the ballpark of 10% in Uttar Pradesh, very different from the population share of Jats, its core support base among Dalits.

BSP vote and seat share in Uttar Pradesh



The roots of BSP's current political predicament can be attributed to various factors. Top leadership's complete inertia to embrace even its own rank and file, its failure to pivot meaningfully to the existing political polarisation in Uttar Pradesh and the country at large and succumbing to the usual sin of

promoting dynastic politics despite having inherited a radical base of grass root organisers are some of them. Politics is a winner-take-all game and it will take a miracle to revive the BSP immediately. But its historical contribution as a vanguard of social justice in Indian democracy will always remain.

[MY INDIA] IN AFFIDAVIT FILED WITH SC

Govt against sub-quotas based solely on income



The Union government on Thursday opposed a plea in the Supreme Court seeking an income-based sub-quota within reserved categories, contending that the constitutional architecture of reservations for SCs, STs and OBCs is founded on historical and social disadvantage and cannot be restructured solely on the basis of economic criteria. The Centre also opposed extending the 'creamy layer' principle to SCs and STs, arguing that the Supreme Court precedent has consistently confined the doctrine to OBCs. In a counter affidavit, the Centre argued that the petitions seek judicial directions to redesign the country's reservation policy – a matter that squarely falls within the executive and legislative domain and cannot be commanded by the Supreme Court through a writ of mandamus.

[MY DELHI] LIFE IN HIDING

Delhi Police nab 'doctor' for cop's murder after 3 decades



For close to three decades, Rajender Bhaiagi lived a normal life. Around the year 2000, he started a job as a physical education (PE) teacher at a government school in Mumbai's upscale Colaba area. A few years later, he moved to Mumbai, a small town in Madhya Pradesh's Aggar district, married a government hospital nurse in 2003, and opened a small clinic. Over time, locals came to know him as 'Dr. Bhaiagi', a nickname inspired by his resemblance to the actor of a scientist from the animated series Motu Patlu. What they did not know, however, was that the man treating patients was wanted in the murder of a Haryana Police constable, among many other cases. Delhi Police cracked the 53-year-old on Tuesday, ending a 28-year manhunt.

'Viksit Bharat' aims to restore India's historical standing: FM

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: 'Viksit Bharat' by 2047 is not an unprecedented ambition but a restoration of India's historical position in the global economy, finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Thursday, citing estimates that India accounted for roughly one-third of global GDP at the beginning of the Common Era and about 8.5% today after centuries of decline.

"What do we really mean by a Viksit Bharat? Prime Minister has given us that goal (to achieve by 2047). This matters, because a goal that is never defined or measured cannot be pursued or achieved," she said while delivering the C.D. Deshmukh Lecture, organised by the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER).

Recalling economist Angus Maddison's historical estimates of world output, Sitharaman said India accounted for roughly one-third of global GDP (adjusted for purchasing power parity) at the beginning of the Common Era and close to a quarter in 1500 CE. Its share fell to about 16% by 1820, 12% by 1870 and roughly 4% by 1950. It touched a low of below 3% in the early 1970s before rising to about 8.5% today.

By 1820 that share had fallen to about 16%, by 1870 to about 12%, and by 1950 to roughly 4%. It touched its lowest of below 3% in the early 1970s, after the centralised Soviet era model we reached 3% of the global GDP.

Explaining the idea behind Viksit Bharat, Sitharaman said it was "not an unprecedented ambition. In a way, it is a restoration."

"As I elucidated in this year's Budget, Viksit Bharat is not an abstract aspiration or merely a target for per capita income. It is a nation where there is zero poverty, 100% good quality education; every citizen can obtain high-quality, affordable and comprehensive healthcare; every young person is equipped with skills and meaningful employment; women participate fully in economic activity;

that enterprise in India is augmented by its ability and access," she said.

"Our banks are for all Indians, not just a select few. Banking must continue to be an instrument of inclusion, ensuring that aspiration finds support rather than barriers," she said, adding that schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana were aimed at turning citizens into entrepreneurs.

The government considers quality education and healthcare non-negotiable national priorities, she said, citing the ancient practice at Thiruvalluvar near Kanchipuram, where an inscription from the reign of Virarajendra Chola (1059 CE) directed that temple revenue be divided among temple rituals, a college with a hostel, and a 15-bed hospital.

"The point is not that charity existed. It is that prosperity was consciously converted into permanent public institutions, embedded in our own tradition," she said.

The finance minister underscored the need to build India's future through a "partnership between generations."

"The older generation carries the wisdom and memory of this nation. That memory does not keep on its own. It fades when it is not transferred," she said.

"The younger generation brings the energy, the innovation, the new ideas, to execute the next phase. They are also the people who will actually live in 2047 and beyond."

Top court draws curtain on Bofors case, rejects petition against 2005 acquittal

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday effectively brought the curtain down on the politically-sensitive Bofors pay-off case by dismissing the only surviving appeal against the 2005 Delhi High Court judgment that quashed all criminal proceedings against the three Hinduja brothers and Swedish arms manufacturer AB Bofors.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran declined to grant any further leave to advocate and BJP leader Ajay K Agarwal, who had challenged the high court verdict, observing that it was not inclined to adjourn a matter that had remained pending since 2018 only on the question how a private individual's appeal could survive after the investigating agency's own challenge had already been dismissed.

The order effectively seals the fate of one of India's longest-running corruption cases, nearly four decades after allegations surfaced that kickbacks were paid in the ₹1,437-core Bofors gun deal.

The scandal rocked the Rajiv Gandhi government, severely dented his clean image, dominated the 1989 general election campaign and is widely regarded as one of the factors that contributed to the Congress losing power that year.

At the outset of Thursday's hearing, Agarwal, appearing virtually in person, sought four weeks' time to delete the names of two deceased respondents.

The bench, however, appeared unconvinced about continuing with the proceedings. "What is all this about the Hinduja brothers and CBI?" it asked.

When informed that the Delhi High Court had exonerated the accused by quashing the proceedings, the top court bench remarked: "All proceedings were quashed. What is this? How many years have passed?"

As Agarwal pointed out that the defence date dated back to 1986 and attempted to explain that CBI's separate appeal had earlier been dismissed because it was already a respondent in his petition and that the agency were asked to appear in his matter, the bench cut him short.

"No, no, dismissed," said the bench.

When Agarwal sought to make further submissions, the bench refused to adjourn the matter, observing, "No question of adjournment. It is a 2018 matter," before dismissing the

appeal.

The dismissal marks the end of the litigation arising out of the high court's May 31, 2005 judgment, in which Justice JS Sodhi quashed all charges against Srichand, Gopichand and Prakash Hinduja as well as the Bofors company, while strongly criticising the Central Bureau of Investigation's handling of the prosecution and observing that the investigation had cost the exchequer nearly ₹250 crore.

The Supreme Court had, in November 2018, refused to entertain CBI's own appeal against the same high court judgment after finding no satisfactory explanation for the agency's delay of 4,522 days in approaching the court.

It had then held that the court was "not convinced" with the reasons furnished to condone the extraordinary delay, though it had observed that CBI could advance its contentions in Agarwal's pending appeal.

The top court had first questioned Agarwal's locus in January 2018, asking how a private individual could maintain an appeal in a criminal prosecution when the investigating agency itself had not challenged the acquittal.

The controversy traces its origins to the ₹1,437-core agreement signed on March 24, 1986, between the Government of India and Swedish arms manufacturer AB Bofors for the supply of 400 155 mm howitzer guns for the Indian Army.

The scandal erupted after Swedish Radio reported in April 1987, that illegal commissions

had been paid to influential Indian politicians and defence officials to secure the contract.

CBI registered an FIR in January 1990, alleging 11 offences including criminal conspiracy, cheating, forgery and corruption against former Bofors president Martin Arbro, alleged middleman Ottavio Quattrocchi and the Hinduja brothers.

The central agency later filed charge sheets against several accused, including Italian businessman Ottavio Quattrocchi, before adding the Hinduja brothers through a supplementary charge sheet in October 2000.

Over the years, however, the prosecution steadily unravelled. Before Justice Sodhi's 2005 judgment, another judge of the Delhi High Court, Justice JD Kapoor, had in February 2004 cleared former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi of any criminal culpability in the case while directing that a forgery charge be framed against the Bofors company.

Subsequently, Quattrocchi was discharged by a Delhi trial court in 2011 after repeated efforts to extradite him failed. He died in 2013, while several other accused, including SK Bhatnagar, also passed away during the prolonged proceedings.

With Thursday's dismissal of Agarwal's appeal, the last judicial challenge to the 2005 acquittal has come to an end, bringing the Bofors prosecution to its final legal close after nearly 40 years.

Tamil Nadu unveils ₹58k-cr agriculture budget, focus on El Niño impact

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CHENNAI: Anticipating 12 districts to be affected due to the Super El Niño phenomenon in the current year, Tamil Nadu has developed a district agricultural contingency plan, state minister R Vinodh said on Thursday, while presenting the ₹58,374.69 crore maiden agriculture budget of the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK) government in the state assembly.

The District Agricultural Contingency Plan prepared by the Tamil Nadu Agricultural University for all districts have been communicated to the district collectors and all steps have been taken up to implement the contingency measures including drought holistically, the agriculture minister said.

Vinodh said that due to the Super El Niño phenomenon, severe impact was anticipated across the country, particularly during the Kharif (short term) season (which is normally during the months of June, July and August).

While making a slew of announcements across the sector, the minister said the Tamil Nadu Soil Fertility Mission would be launched as a five-year plan at an estimated outlay of ₹600 crore to ensure that future generations inherit fertile Tamil



Agriculture minister R Vinodh presents TVK government's first agriculture budget in the Tamil Nadu assembly on Thursday.

soils. In 2026-27, the Tamil Nadu Soil Fertility Mission would be implemented with 10 components at a cost of ₹122.51 crore.

In his over two hour speech, he said, to encourage balanced use of fertilisers based on the soil fertility status, Soil Health Cards will be distributed to 100,000 farmers with an allocation of ₹44 crore from state funds.

The government would also utilise Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning technologies to provide farmers with real-time information on soil health and crop cultivation.

"Accordingly, by integrating Artificial Intelligence, and Machine Learning technologies, comprehensive technical advisories and services related to

launch demonstration projects across 2,000 acres and develop monitoring and verification protocol for carbon trading. Under the scheme, farmers will be enabled to earn supplementary income through carbon credits by adopting existing sustainable cultivation methods, specifically emission-reducing practices such as Direct Seeded Rice (DSR) and Alternate Wetting and Drying (AWD) irrigation techniques.

To promote dairy development, the Minister said 500 medium-scale dairy farms comprising 5 milch animals would be established.

The Opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) slammed the TVK for not mentioning anything "substantial" in the agricultural budget.

Clad in black shirt along with party lawmakers, the Leader of Opposition, Udhayanidhi Stalin said, "as promised in the election manifesto of the TVK, farmers expected that there will be an announcement for a complete loan waiver. But as usual the chief minister has not made any kind of response to that."

The general secretary of All India Farmers' Organisation, K. K. Palanisami said farmers had high expectations on this budget.

"But only massive disappointment remained for them as there is no single important scheme announced for them," he said.

He noted that the state government is fully committed to extend its cooperation for the successful implementation of the project.

Andhra cabinet decides to withdraw Disha Bill

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HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh cabinet, chaired by chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu, on Thursday decided to withdraw the Disha Bill brought in by the previous YSR Congress Party government to ensure speedy investigation and trial of crimes against women and children.

The Andhra Pradesh Disha Bill, 2019 (Criminal Law Amendment Bill) was unanimously passed by the state legislature on December 13, 2019. It aims to fast-track rape and sexual offence cases to a maximum of 21 days and introduce the death penalty for heinous crimes.

Briefing reporters after the cabinet meeting, state information and public relations minister P. Karthikeyan said the bill had been sent to the President for assent. The bill has since been pending in the President's Office. "The Union ministry of home affairs had sought clarifications on several provisions. It had advised the state government to withdraw the bill and submit a revised legislation after incorporating suggestions from various Central government departments," the minister said.

He said the cabinet noted that the Centre has since replaced the Indian Penal Code (IPC) and the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPc) with the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 and the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023.

THE ANDHRA PRADESH DISHA BILL, 2019 AIMS TO FAST-TRACK RAPE AND SEXUAL OFFENCE TRIALS AND INTRODUCE DEATH PENALTY

which came into force nationwide on July 1, 2024.

"These new criminal laws have already incorporated stronger legal provisions aimed at protecting women and children, thereby rendering the objectives envisaged under the Disha Bill," he said.

Based on the recommendations of the director general of police and the law department, and considering the Centre's advice, the cabinet formally approved the withdrawal of the Disha Bill, the minister said.

The policy adopted a zero-tolerance approach to eliminate pedestrian fatalities by removing encroachments from footpaths and creating dedicated, safe walkways across urban areas.

Parthasarathy said scientific road safety audits will be conducted on all urban roads with priority being given to 15-20 accident-prone black spots, major

junctions, school zones and areas with high pedestrian traffic based on accident data from the last two to three years.

"The government will upgrade footpaths, pedestrian crossings, subways, foot overbridges and street lighting in accordance with Indian Roads Congress (IRC) standards. Encroachments will be monitored through GIS mapping, CCTV surveillance and camera-based enforcement," he said.

The cabinet also approved the draft Andhra Pradesh Omnibus (Ease of Doing Business) Act, 2026, which aims to amend multiple laws through a single act, to simplify outdated regulations, remove procedural hurdles and create a more investor-friendly industrial environment.

The cabinet approved a proposal to invite fresh tenders for the Amaravati Eye project in the capital city under the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) mode through the Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) model.

The cabinet approved the draft Andhra Pradesh Public-Private Partnership (PPP) Policy, 2026, aimed at transforming the state into a major investment destination.

"The policy seeks to attract private investment in sectors such as transport, logistics, ports, airports, urban infrastructure, digital technology, industrial development, renewable energy and tourism," he said.

FATHER BOOKED, 3 HELD FOR RAPING MINOR IN KERALA

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Three people have been arrested on Thursday in connection with the rape of a Class 10 girl in Kerala's Pathanamthitta district, a police officer said.

Six people, including the victim's father, have been booked under the PoCSO Act for subjecting the girl to rape and sexual abuse for the past three years, the officer said.

Two people arrested three people on Thursday. They include the owner of the rented house in which the Class 10 student lived with her mother as well as two neighbours in the same building. The girl's father is currently abroad and we are making efforts to bring him back," said a senior officer at the Malayalam police station where the FIR was registered last week.

The girl has been subjected to sexual abuse since she was in school, the officer said, adding that police was informed by Childline officials after the girl confided about the abuse to her classmates.

The girl was subjected to abuse at the rented house while her mother was outside for work. Her father left for UAE for employment last month, the officer said. Police have conducted the medical examination of the victim and are proceeding with the investigation.

3 AIADMK MLAs meet TVK minister N Anand

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Three lawmakers from the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) met minister N Anand on Thursday, the general secretary of Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK) on Thursday, while presenting the ₹58,374.69 crore maiden agriculture budget of the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK) government in the state assembly.

Besides Velumani and Shanmugam, MLAs K. P. Anbalagan and M. Anand, who are also the state water resources minister, at the secretariat. The meeting comes amid ongoing tension in the AIADMK after party general secretary Edappadi K. Palanisami recently assigned new responsibilities to the leaders, which they declined, stating that they preferred to remain as ordinary party workers. The three leaders have also been avoiding direct meetings with Palanisami, further deepening speculation about an internal discord.

The lawmakers, however, dismissed speculation about joining the TVK when asked about their meeting with Anand. "You are spreading rumours like this. AIADMK is my party and it was clarified long ago. But people are unnecessarily spreading such rumours on WhatsApp. None of that is true, there is no room for such questions at all," Velumani said. "AIADMK is the party that nurtured me. Some people are just stirring up such rumours," he added.

Nationwide movement for legislative bodies' 50% BC quota: Kavitha

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: Telangana Raksha Sena (TRS) president and former MP Kavitha Kavitha on Thursday announced the launch of a nationwide movement for securing 50% reservations for other backward classes (OBCs) in legislative bodies.

Addressing a huge gathering at part of Samajika Nyaya Telangana Sankalpa Sabha (Convention to achieve social justice) at Saroorangar indoor stadium in Hyderabad, she said true social justice lies in the equitable distribution of national resources among all sections of the society, which is currently pending approval with the Union government, must be cleared without any delay.

She demanded that the OBC Reservation Bill granting 50% representation in legislative bodies must be officially passed before the next budget session of the Parliament. "If the Centre fails to pass the bill, we will mobilize thousands of activists and lead a massive 'Chalo Delhi' rally with over 1,000 cars."

The meeting formally passed 11 major resolutions, including launch of a nationwide movement for achieving 50% reservation for OBCs in legislative bodies; conferring of Bharat Ratna on social reformers Mahatma Jyotiba Phule and Savitribai Phule; ensuring zero diversion of land for OBCs in the constitutionally allocated SC/ST funds; issuance of special recruitment notifications immediately to fill all pending SC and ST backlog job vacancies in both central and state government departments. It also resolved to demand immediate introduction and passage of the Women's Reservation Bill without linking it to the delimitation process.

"Had OBCs been granted reservations on par with SCs and STs immediately after Independence, India would have been competing for the pinnacle of global superpower status along

Vijay urges PM to implement project linking 3 major rivers

S Vijay Karthik
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to take up the Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar river linking project on a fast track basis and demanded that the project be declared as of 'national importance'.

Requesting the PM for the formation of a Special Purpose Vehicle with participation of the Centre and the beneficiary states, Vijay said, "Its early execution would benefit the people and farming communities of Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka."

Vijay pointed out that the most sustainable means of addressing the growing water requirements would be the implementation of the project as it would facilitate the transfer of surplus floodwaters from water-deficient regions.

He underlined that the Pudukottai, Sivagangai, Ramanathapuram and Virudhunagar districts are chronically water-scarce and highly drought prone areas.

In a letter to Modi on Thursday, Vijay said the National



C. Joseph Vijay

Water Development Agency (NWDA) has prepared the Detailed Project Report for the Godavari-Pennar-Palar-Vellar link as Phase 1 of the larger project.

Vijay requested Modi to direct the Union ministry of Jal Shakti and the NWDA to expedite consultations with the stakeholder States and facilitate an early consensus on outstanding issues.

"He appealed to the Prime Minister to finalise the Detailed Project Report for extending the link up to the Kattal Barrage across the river Cauvery (in Karur district) as the current project alone terminates few kilometres upstream of the Cauvery river."

The chief minister suggested considering establishing a dedicated special purpose vehicle (SPV) for a coordinated and time-bound execution.

SIT files FIR against three in Sabarimala ghee irregularities case

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A Kerala high court-constituted SIT registered an FIR on Thursday as part of its probe into the alleged irregularities in the procurement and supply of ghee used to the Sabarimala and Ayappa temple, officials said.

Insiders in the special investigation team (SIT) said the FIR names former Travancore Development Board (TDB) president P. Prasanth, former board member A. Ajikumar and former administrative officer Murali Prasad, who died in June this year.

It was during their tenure the decision was taken to procure ghee at lower price, officials said. The FIR has been submitted before the Vigilance Court in Kollam, the insiders said.

The trio is also accused in the Sabarimala ghee loss case, which is being investigated by the high court last year. Prasanth and Ajikumar were recently arrested in the gold loss case. A division bench of Justices Raju Vyjayaraghavan V and K. Jayakumar on Wednesday constituted the SIT and directed that it be headed by Vigilance and

FIR NAMING EX-TDB MEMBERS HAS BEEN SUBMITTED BEFORE VIGILANCE COURT IN KOLLAM.

Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) superintendent of police M. J. Sojan. Sojan, who heads the VACB's Ernakulam Special Cell, is also probing alleged criminal misappropriation of proceeds from the sale of 'Adya Sisham Ghee' at the Sabarimala temple.

The HC directed the SIT to carry out the investigation with "utmost diligence and vigour" and examine all issues flagged in the report submitted by the Chief Vigilance and Security Officer of the TDB. The bench also directed the SIT to submit a progress report before the court within one month.

The Kerala government had recently ordered a probe following allegations that the ghee supplied by state-run dairy cooperative Milma to the Sabarimala temple for the 2025-26 pilgrimage season was of inferior quality and that there were irregularities in the quantity supplied.

NON-BAILABLE WARRANT AGAINST DMK'S PONMUDY

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CHENNAI: A Chennai court on Thursday issued a non-bailable warrant against former minister and veteran leader of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) P. K. Ponmudy over his alleged remarks about Hindu faith and women hurting religious sentiments by promoting lust.

Magistrate S. Sundarapandian of the Metropolitan magistrate court in George Town, dismissed a petition filed on behalf of Ponmudy seeking exemption from his personal appearance.

The court issued non-bailable warrant and directed police to produce him before the court on or before September 10.

The former minister had made some remarks over Saivite and Vaishnavites and women during a meeting in the DMK office in April 2025. His comments triggered widespread outrage leading to his removal from party posts and then MK Stalin led-cabinet.

A case was filed by BJP leader Uma Anandhan seeking action against him for offending religious sentiments under Section 295 and Section 302.

'Red alert' issued for three Kerala districts

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Thursday issued a 'red alert' for three districts in Kerala, forecasting extremely heavy rainfall and strong winds, even as floodwaters began receding in several affected areas, officials said.

The IMD issued a 'red alert' for Pathanamthitta, Kottayam and Idukki districts at 1 p.m. The IMD also issued an 'orange alert' for Kollam, Alappuzha, Ernakulam, Kannur and Kasargod districts. Officials said floodwaters had begun receding in several low-lying areas.

The Kerala HC grants bail to 6 more accused in May ED attack case. **KOCHI:** The Kerala high court on Thursday granted bail to six more people accused of attacking ED officials following a search at former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan's residence.

The court granted bail to Raventh, R. Umrikrishnan, Umni D. S. P. Bin, Dinesh B. Nair and Dinakar in the case, saying that according to the prosecution the investigation was almost over, the accused had no criminal antecedents involving serious offences and the victims had not sustained any serious injuries. The HC had earlier this week granted bail to 17 other accused and one of the accused was given the relief by the trial court.

Spl panel for Vizag Bay City works announced

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu has announced the constitution of a special committee to oversee the implementation of the Vizag Bay City project, as an anchor for the comprehensive development of the Visakhapatnam Economic Region (VER).

Reviewing the VER development plans at his camp office on Wednesday, Naidu said the Visakhapatnam Bay City project would play a pivotal role in driving large-scale urbanisation and infrastructure development. He instructed officials to converge funds from various government schemes for the project and make concerted efforts to secure financial assistance from the Centre.

The Vizag Bay City project involves development of the 25-km-long beach corridor between the Dubai, Junnarai Beach, Barcelona's La Barceloneta, and Singapore's East Coast Park.

for request for proposal (RFP) tenders for selection of consultant for the preparation of area development plan for the Vizag Bay City.

The project envisages development of Vizag Bay City as a future ready, technology enabled, world class coastal city that integrates natural assets with comprehensive high-quality urban experiences.

The Vizag Bay City will have iconic seafloor developments, high-end retail avenues, international class hospitality ecosystem, integrated cultural systems, and smart urban systems. The government proposes a comprehensive planning and development of key beach zones with pedestrian promenades and boardwalks with integrated lighting, landscaping, 80-100 beach shacks, 8-10 beach clubs, 50+ fine-dining establishments.

During the review meeting, the chief minister said the Bay City project should be leveraged to attract investments of around ₹15 lakh crore, including nearly ₹5.3 lakh crore from the private sector, while government investments of ₹3.5 lakh crore to ₹4 lakh crore would be required to create supporting infrastructure.

ANDHRA RECORDS SIX-FOLD HIKE IN FDI IN LAST 2 YRS, SAYS NAIDU GOVT

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh recorded a sharp six-fold increase in FDI inflows in FY 2024-25 to USD 233.4 million in FY 2024-25, before rising further to USD 608.59 million in FY 2025-26, compared to just USD 92.13 million in FY 2023-24, an increase of more than six times in less than two years.

Quoting the data furnished by the Union minister, the official statement said there was a steady rise in FDI inflows into the coalition government assumed office.

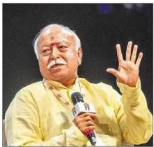
"The FDI inflows increased from USD 92.13 million in FY 2023-24 to USD 233.4 million in FY 2024-25, before rising further to USD 608.59 million in FY 2025-26. In effect, the government more than doubled FDI in its first year and nearly tripled it in its second year," it said.

How can they be anti-national?

RSS chief reaches out to Centre

Niraj Pandit
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MUMBAI: The grievances of Gen Z are genuine and protest is also a form of dialogue. Rashtriya Swamasevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Thursday in a mega outreach to younger people against the backdrop of student protests in Delhi last month.



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat

Addressing around 2,000 students aged between 15 and 19 from across the country, Bhagwat also spoke on employment, reservation, equal rights for women and those of the LGBTQIA+ community, and India's relations with neighbouring countries.

Speaking about the recent protests at Jantar Mantar, Bhagwat said the protesters should not be called "anti-national".

"Gen Z are our own children. If they protest for an issue, how can they become anti-national? Their concerns should be heard. In a democracy, protest is also a form of dialogue. There is nothing wrong in protesting, but it should not be used to create divisions in society," he said, acknowledging that improvements were needed in India's education policy for which discussions are necessary.

"I believe in Gen Z and Gen Alpha unlike because they are an honest generation," he added.

Gen Z refers to people born between 1997 and 2012.

Bhagwat was speaking at an interaction with Rishabh Shah, founder of India's International Movement to Unite Nations (IMUN) — a youth organisation — at the Annual Championship Conference held in Mumbai, to mark its 10th anniversary.

Before the session, the moderator gathered questions from the students to ask Bhagwat, whose responses drew loud cheers from the audience.

Bhagwat said that the LGBTQIA+ community should be accepted as a part of society and even proposed that companionship laws could be an alternative to marriage.

"Marriage is an institution that helps prepare the next generation

to become responsible members of society, and any changes to this system should be made carefully," he made the comment when he was specifically questioned about the legality of same-sex marriages.

"In such cases, we need to consider companionship which society can accept; once that is achieved, there is no need to frame a law."

On the question of reservation, Bhagwat said quotas would be necessary as long as inequality existed in society. "While some communities have benefited from reservation and progressed, others still remain deprived and are now raising their voices for equal opportunities," said Bhagwat. He suggested that people who had already benefited through reservation could consider giving up a part of the benefits for more deprived sections. "Those who benefited already through reservation could consider giving up a part of their benefits for more deprived sections," Bhagwat said.

Bhagwat said education should not become a business and every child should have access to quality education, and stressed on the need to review fee structures, improve teacher training and increase public participation in school development. Supporting higher budget for education, Bhagwat backed the demand that 6% of the country's total budget be spent on this sector. He expressed faith that this could be achieved through dialogue, without the need for protests.

When he was asked about allegations of faith-charges and of pellet guns on protest students in Delhi, Bhagwat reserved comments, saying he did not have full information about the incident. "I do not know why the faith-charges happened or whether pellet guns were used. I need to study the facts before giving an opinion," he said.

While he did not see a problem with the use of social media, he insisted that "people develop self-discipline and use social media responsibly".

Responding to a query on India's relations with Pakistan and China, he said the youth should stand by the government's decisions during times of conflict with neighbouring nations. "But that should not sever the ties which are already there. China's people say that for 2,000 years, Bharat gave them values, and Pakistan was Bharat less than 10 years ago. This should not be forgotten; these ties cannot be severed, they can be put on hold till there is conflict. But what is the Bharat solution? The Bharat solution is not conquering or obligating others, but to form that harmonious, assimilating process. That requires dialogue. So, conflicts may halt all these relations but they may not sever, they should not," he said.

CIP to launch nationwide outreach campaign in Sep

MUMBAI: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) has announced a nationwide outreach campaign to understand the issues, concerns and expectations of people, particularly the youth. Titled 'Kya Bolhi Public', the campaign will be launched in September. The decision was taken during a two-day convener of the party's core committee, which ended on Thursday, held at the residence of CJP's founder, Abhi Jethi Dipke, in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar.

"Beginning in September, we will travel across the country to understand the expectations, aspirations and concerns of the people. We believe those in power are no longer willing to listen to people's

issues and have become disconnected from the public," said Dipke on Thursday.

Dipke had earlier said that the CJP would continue to function as a pressure group instead of entering electoral politics.

On Thursday, he said the CJP would make unemployment a central issue. "Gen Z has shown that it is willing to take to the streets and if these concerns continue to be ignored, they will do so again."

Later in the day, he said on X that his "info was put on display by a US based AI startup to showcase their Altool during FutureCrime Summit 2026 at Bharat Mandapam... in the presence of many G20 officials".

CENTRE CONSULTS SENIOR COPS ON HOW TO CONTROL LARGE CROWDS

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NEW DELHI: The Centre has sought insights from senior police officers across the country on measures to control large crowds, recognising the need to calibrate its strategy after the 2025, when the PM's visits to 23 countries cost ₹187.83 crore, figures provided by minister of state for external affairs Pabitra Margherita to the Rajya Sabha on Thursday.

The minister was responding to a question from Aam Aadmi Party MP Sanjay Singh and CJP MP V. Sivasadan.

Expenses incurred on other trips this year including ₹5.57 crore for a visit to Malaysia in February, ₹1.97 crore for a visit to the United Arab Emirates (UAE), ₹3.6 crore for a visit to the Netherlands, ₹4.23 crore on a visit to Italy (all in May), ₹4.77 crore on a visit to the Slovak Republic in June, ₹3.57 crore on a visit to Indonesia, ₹1.18 crore on a visit to Australia and ₹5.43 crore on a visit to New Zealand (all in July).

"High level visits by the Prime Minister are established means of fostering closer relations with foreign countries and promoting India's engagements at bilateral, regional and global levels," Margherita said in his reply.

"These visits, and the understandings and agreements concluded therein, facilitate the strengthening of partnerships across a wide range of sectors, including technology, innovation, trade and investment, defence and energy cooperation,

₹557 cr spent on PM's foreign visits since '21

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PM Narendra Modi

NEW DELHI: A total of ₹557.1 crore has been spent on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visits to 77 countries since 2021, including ₹74.59 crore on trips to 12 nations this year, according to information provided by the central government in Parliament on Thursday.

The highest expenditure during this period was recorded in 2025, when the PM's visits to 23 countries cost ₹187.83 crore, figures provided by minister of state for external affairs Pabitra Margherita to the Rajya Sabha on Thursday.

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The PM's trips between 2021 and 2026 resulted in signing of 316 agreements, including government-to-government pacts and MoUs between government institutions and research bodies and universities, in fields of defence, trade, investment, nuclear energy research and development, healthcare, renewable energy, space, sports and culture, he said.

All the trips this year, the PM's visit to Norway in May for a

and resilient supply chains, among others."

Of the visits to 25 countries in 2025, the five most expensive were to France (₹25.4 crore), followed by Brazil (₹17.72 crore), the US (₹16.54 crore), Saudi Arabia (₹15.54 crore), and China (₹10.6 crore).

The PM visited 17 countries in 2024 that cost a total of ₹109.51 crore, with the five most expensive trips being to the US (₹15.33 crore), followed by Italy (₹14.36 crore), Russia (₹10.75 crore), Poland (₹10.1 crore), and Singapore (₹7.75 crore).

There were visits to 11 countries in 2023 that cost a total of ₹93.63 crore, with the most expensive trips being to the US (₹22.89 crore), Japan (₹17.19 crore), France (₹13.74 crore), and Germany (₹14.47 crore). On a trip to Germany in 2023, the PM's visits to 10 countries in 2022 cost a total of ₹55.83 crore, with the most expensive trips being to Germany (₹14.47 crore), followed by a visit to Germany (₹9.44 crore), and Japan (₹8.68 crore).

The PM visited nine countries in 2021, resulting in total expenditure of ₹36.12 crore. This included a visit to the US that cost ₹19.63 crore and a trip to the UK that cost ₹8.57 crore.

Margherita's response also provided certain figures of the expenditure on visits by the PM under the previous UPA government for reference purposes, and noted that ₹10.74 crore was spent on a visit to the US in 2011, ₹8.33 crore on a visit to France in 2011, ₹9.95 crore on a visit to Russia in 2013, and ₹8.02 crore on a visit to Germany in 2013.

"These figures show actual expenditure without adjusting for inflation or currency fluctuations," he said.

Centre, Meta to discuss policies, compliances, algos

Sejal Sharma
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minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Wednesday for the first time. But becoming inaccessible on the platform for around five hours on July 28, 'I apologise to the minister on behalf of Meta for error restricting the PM Modi's content moderation policies, algorithms, and compliance mechanisms, after the temporary removal of access to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook Reel raised concerns within the government, as a senior official from the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) said.

This comes after Meta's chief global affairs officer Joel Kaplan met and apologised to Union



Meta officials leave the MeitY office on Thursday.

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High Commissioner of South Africa to India Anil Sookal

NEW DELHI: South Africa's high commissioner to India, Anil Sookal, has been recalled for being part of a meeting between former president Jacob Zuma and one of the Gupta brothers who are wanted by South African authorities on charges of political corruption.

The move was announced by South African foreign minister Marthinus van Regenmortel on Thursday, after photographs emerged of Zuma with Ajay Gupta and Sookal at a ceremony at a temple in Haridwar on June 26. Zuma, 82, has been recalled for being part of a meeting between former president Jacob Zuma and one of the Gupta brothers who are wanted by South African authorities on charges of political corruption.

The move was announced by South African foreign minister Marthinus van Regenmortel on Thursday, after photographs emerged of Zuma with Ajay Gupta and Sookal at a ceremony at a temple in Haridwar on June 26. Zuma, 82, has been recalled for being part of a meeting between former president Jacob Zuma and one of the Gupta brothers who are wanted by South African authorities on charges of political corruption.

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STUDENTS ON STIR IN J'KHAND FORM PANEL FOR TALKS WITH STATE GOVT

Raj Kumar
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RANCHI: Students and job aspirants protesting against online examination cancellations and alleged irregularities by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC), under the umbrella of JPSC-JSSC Reforma Manch, announced on Thursday that they had formed a joint student panel to hold talks with the state government. The move comes a day after chief minister Hemant Soren invited the protesters for a dialogue.

The delegation comprises eight student representatives, two veteran journalists and a prominent legal expert. The students submitted the names of their panel to Ranchi sub-divisional (SDM) officer Kumar Rajat. "We have submitted the list of our 11-member delegation to the government, but there has been no response so far," Manch spokesperson Piyush Kumar Singh said.

SDM Rajat could not be contacted for comment despite repeated efforts. An official familiar with the matter said the government was not inclined to allow the advocate and journalists to attend the meeting.

Need to bolster legal framework to deal with data thefts: SC

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday underscored the need to strengthen India's legal framework to deal with data thefts, as it agreed to examine a plea seeking a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the alleged hacking and theft of personal data from a technology company by 150,000 citizens stored by a technology company.

"We understand the seriousness, that is why in the other case, we had requested the learned solicitor general to consider if the law [on data breaches] should be made more stringent," a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, and Justices Jyoti Singh and V Mohana, observed while issuing notice on a petition filed by Vritra Technologies Pvt Ltd.

The petition, filed under Article 32 of the Constitution, alleged a large-scale cyber intrusion involving unauthorised access to highly sensitive personal information, including medical records, insurance claim details, Aadhaar-linked information and other personally identifiable data, contending that the breach has grave implications for the fundamental right to privacy under Article 21.

We have requested the learned solicitor general to consider if the law [on data breaches] should be made more stringent

SUPREME COURT

Appearing for the petitioner, senior counsel K Parameshwar and advocate Nupur Sharma submitted that the alleged data breach spanned six states and accused the investigating authorities of failing to conduct a meaningful probe despite repeated complaints.

"I gave them the details of the Singapore server where the medical records of nearly 15 lakh [150,000] Indian citizens have gone. Even today, the FIR is against unknown persons. How do I trust this investigation? I argued claim details, Aadhaar-linked information and other personally identifiable data, contending that the breach has grave implications for the fundamental right to privacy under Article 21.

Rijiju calls Rahul in new bid to end logjam

Smriti Kak Ramchandran and Saubhadra Chatterji
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Kiren Rijiju and Rahul Gandhi

NEW DELHI: The Union government on Thursday made a fresh attempt to break the ongoing deadlock in Parliament with parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju reaching out to Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Thursday, aimed to extend support for the delimitation bill.

According to people aware of the details, during the telephone conversation between the two, Gandhi is learnt to have said that there should be an all-party meeting to discuss the issue further, which Rijiju did not agree to.

On Wednesday, Rijiju met Gandhi at the latter's office for more than 40 minutes to discuss the delimitation bill and ways to end the logjam.

Rijiju for his part said, "I had a productive conversation with Rahul Gandhi. We made a request regarding a specific matter and also discussed other issues. We desire continuous communication and coordinated action with the Congress and other opposition parties. We may be political opponents, but we are not enemies; therefore, we should work together in the national interest. However, the impression created outside is that they are determined not to let Parliament function at all, but who ultimately suffers

from that?"

He said given the disruptions in Parliament, there is an impression created outside is that the opposition "is determined not to let Parliament function at all, but who ultimately suffers from that?"

According to a Congress leader, the government's outreach is aimed at pushing the delimitation bill, which had been defeated once this year. The government has renewed its efforts to reach out to the Opposition over the delimitation bill. They don't have the numbers. So they are trying to take the waters," said a senior leader.

The Congress party is set to issue a three-day whip demanding the presence of all its lawmakers for the last week of the monsoon session—a bid to prepare against the FCRA bill and to thwart any possible attempt to bring the delimitation-related Constitution amendment bill, a leader aware of the matter said.

DMK's Tiruchi Siva said the party will not speculate on outside the support the delimitation bill, it sees the provisions of the bill.

Govt nears completion of its legislative agenda

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: The Union government has almost entirely cleared its legislative agenda, securing a significant advantage of the Opposition-sponsored protests, getting seven bills passed in the Lok Sabha and six in the Rajya Sabha with five more days left in the monsoon session of Parliament.

The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 (which was brought in the backdrop of massive student protests by students against alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG 2026) was the only legislation to be passed while the Rajya Sabha discussed it for 6.30 hours.

"It is indeed an achievement to clear a number of bills with one week left in the session. But we should not be complacent for passing the bills amid din," a senior government functionary told HT.

So far, Parliament has also passed The Regulation of Online News and Information (Amendment) Bill, 2026; The Prevention of Insults to

National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026; and The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026. The Lok Sabha has cleared The Taxation and Other Financial Measures Bill, 2026; and The Bankers' Books Evidence Bill, 2026; while the Rajya Sabha has passed the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in the session.

To be sure, the government has delayed two controversial bills—the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, and the Indian Statistical Institute Bill, 2026—amid protests by the Opposition. Government managers indicated the ruling dispensation is likely to push the FCRA amendment bill for passage in the last week.

Both houses have repeatedly seen disruptions amid protests by the Opposition seeking home minister Amit Shah's response over police excess on protesters.

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla renewed MPs to engage in debate. "As it is the highest form of democracy, it is the responsibility of us all to engage in discussion and dialogue within the House and to express our points of agreement and disagreement."

INDIAN-ORIGIN DOC SEEKING PARDON GAVE M.A.G.A. 1 MN

Shashank Mattoo
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WASHINGTON: Indian-American doctor Krishna Tripuraneni—who served two years in prison for a 2018 conviction for under-reporting his income by \$18 million and is actively seeking a pardon from the Trump administration—has been named as one of the largest Indian origin political donors to US President Donald Trump in 2026. According to US Federal Election Commission records, Tripuraneni gave \$1 million to Donald Trump's MAGA Inc political fund in June this year.

The donation makes Tripuraneni, a Florida-based retired gastroenterologist, one of the biggest Indian-American donors to Trump and the ruling Republican party this year following Palanichandran Technology Officer Shyam Sankar, who donated over \$1 million this year, ahead of the crucial mid-term elections slated for November 2026. In 2025, Tripuraneni filed an application with the office of the US Pardon Attorney earlier this year seeking a "pardon after completion of sentence." It granted a pardon will restore Tripuraneni's civil rights including his right to vote in US polls, serve on a jury and hold public office. Tripuraneni did not respond to HT's queries on the matter.

Sc expands subvention scam probe, pulls up CBI

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday expanded the scope of the probe into the subvention scheme scam involving builders-banks nexus by directing the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to share details of such cases where ED is to take cognisance of matters with regard to proceeds of crime.

The bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said, "The CBI is to inform ED in respect of details of such cases where ED is to take cognisance of matters with regard to proceeds of crime."

With probe in only 18 of the 50 cases passed by CBI so far, the court pressed directions for a "time-bound, expedient" probe by directing six banks and financial corporations to process prosecution sanction within two weeks against their officials found prima facie guilty in the CBI probe conducted so far. The court directed CBI to further probe into additional complaints forwarded to it involving subvention-related allegations by home buyers of Co-operative (Kannur), Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Rudra Buildwell (Greater Noida) among others and submit a status report by the next date of hearing.

In addition, the agency was directed to examine the lapses in the subvention scheme where the builder and lessee of the land were different entities and yet a tripartite agreement was signed between the builder, buyer and bank without involving the lessee.

SUPREME COURT

CBI has acquired the reputation of keeping the probe pending for years. We expect they come out with probe in a time-bound manner

HT

The court asked the CBI to examine whether such an exclusion was done ignorantly or consciously and whether the same led to any wrongful loss.

The bench, also comprising justices Jaymalaya Bagchi and V Mohana, was critical of the pace of investigation conducted by CBI. It said, "CBI has acquired the reputation of keeping the investigation pending for years and years. We expect they come out with investigation in a time-bound manner."

Additional solicitor general (ASG) Ashwarya Bhat, appearing for CBI, informed the court that the cases involved 25 bank housing financial companies, 56 builders spread across multiple projects across the country. She pointed out that the Prevention of Corruption Act has been invoked against officials of six banks — Bank of India, State Bank of India, UCO Bank, HDFC, ICICI Bank and Samman Capital. In all, she said 34

prosecution sanctions are awaited and till date the banks have not responded.

Bhat further stated that CBI even requisitioned for additional personnel from the police forces in the states of Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Punjab, and Karnataka. However, they have not yet responded.

The court told Bhat, "We leave it to you to tell them (CBI) what high quality of investigation we require. You must quickly investigate the matters with you so that the next lot where the CBI feels there is a need to trace proceeds of crime, you can refer the matter to ED."

The order by the court said, "In order to facilitate expeditious and time-bound investigation by CBI, we direct the competent authorities of the six banks to expeditiously process and accord necessary sanction under section 19 of PC Act for prosecution of their offi-

cials who are prima facie found involved. Let the needful be done in two weeks falling which competent authority will have to submit an explanation to this court."

"Sanction should be promptly granted when it is a court-mandated investigation," the bench said. It further directed the DGBs of the states supposed to spare personnel for CBI to do so within 10 days.

Advocate Rajiv Jain, assisting the court as amicus pointed out that of the 18 cases probed by CBI, charge sheets have been filed in 17 cases and charges framed in 13. Jain said that on analysing the three charge sheets he noted several projects belonging to the same builder that may be investigated by the agency.

"It has been noticed that CBI is only probing the facts of the petition forwarded to them and not looking into anything beyond it," Jain said. The court directed CBI to scrutinise and conduct thorough investigation into the aspects highlighted by the amicus.

A subvention scheme is a tripartite agreement between the builder, homebuyer and bank where banks agree to release loans to builders who pay the EMIs till a specified cut-off or till the date of handing over possession of flat.

The court had directed a CBI probe after it came across the plight faced by homebuyers who alleged that despite being defrauded by builders who failed to deliver flats in time, they were unnecessarily saddled with the burden of paying EMIs under the subvention scheme.

Bengal reaches out to Tata, seeks to resolve dispute over Singur

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KOLKATA: The West Bengal government has initiated talks with the Tata Group to set up new industries and resolve a legal dispute over compensation of ₹765.78 crore that the previous government under the Trinamool Congress (TMC) did not pay to Tata Motors for losses suffered in aborting the Nano car project at Singur in 2008 following a two-year agitation by then-opposition leader Mamata Banerjee, officials aware of the matter said.

"Our officers went to Mumbai this week and talked to the Tata Group. Of course, we want them to return to Bengal. Had Mr Ratan Tata been alive I would have touched his feet and requested him to set up an industry here," industry minister Tapas Roy said.

"Our state is saddled with debts piled up by the former government. The court ordered that a compensation of around ₹766 crore be paid to the Tatas. All these issues are being discussed," Roy added.

Officials aware of the matter said if the initial talks bear fruit then finance minister Swapna Dasgupta and Roy may visit Mumbai.

Known for multi-crop farming, Hooghly district's Singur made headlines in 2006 when Tata Motors set its sights on the land to build its T-10 car, the Nano. The Left Front government acquired 597.12 acres along

IF TALKS BEAR FRUIT THEN STATE FINANCE MINISTER MAY VISIT MUMBAI, OFFICIALS AWARE OF THE MATTER SAID

the NH-2 and handed it over to the company. However, Mamata Banerjee, then in the Opposition called a hunger strike demanding the return of 347 acres of farmland that she alleged was "forcibly" acquired.

Following a two-year agitation by Banerjee and several litigations, the Tatas moved out in October 2008 and shifted the project to Gujarat's Sanand.

The Tata Group moved the Calcutta high court seeking compensation for the losses and the matter was referred to an arbitration tribunal which directed the West Bengal Industrial Development Corporation (WBIDC) in October 2023 to pay a compensation of ₹765.78 crore along with 1% annual interest to the Tatas. The state challenged this order at the Supreme Court but its appeal was rejected.

"On May 7, three days after the BJP won the Bengal polls, the Calcutta high court turned down WBIDC's prayer for an unconditional stay on the arbitration tribunal's order and directed WBIDC, a senior state official said. "Efforts are being made to reach an out-of-court settlement with the Tata Group," he added, asking not to be named.

WB to delete 57K Awas beneficiaries after SIR

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KOLKATA: At least 57,000 names will be removed from the list of beneficiaries of Awas Yojana (housing scheme) in West Bengal because they were already struck off from the electoral rolls during the special intensive revision (SIR) in 2025, state panchayat and rural development minister Dilip Ghosh said on Thursday.

"Around 9.1 million names have been struck off from the voters' list during SIR in the state. Of these, around 57,000 people received assistance under the Awas yojana. They are not eligible to avail this fund and their names will be struck off," said Ghosh.

He was speaking at an administrative programme at the state secretariat where chief minister Suvedu Adhikari handed over cheques and transferred funds directly to the bank accounts of around 1.02 million beneficiaries of the state's housing scheme.

"Of the three million beneficiaries, who have received the

funds, around 12,500 individuals are not eligible for the scheme. They received the funds illegally. Action is being initiated against them and further enquiry is being done. We have already started the process to recover the funds from around 1,000 such beneficiaries," said Ghosh.

The Centre had stopped releasing funds to the state under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY) following allegations related to nepotism and financial irregularities in 2022. The previous TMC government headed by Mamata Banerjee launched a parallel scheme "Banglar Bari" with its own funds in 2024.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) after coming to power in May this year, conducted a survey to weed out fake names. On Thursday, 1,020,370 beneficiaries were handed over the second instalment of ₹60,000 each. Verification for the remaining beneficiaries was underway, officials said. The name of the scheme was also changed from Banglar Bari to Paschim Banga Awas Yojana.

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Atiq's family in spotlight

Atiq Ahmed and brother Ashraf: Shot dead in police custody on April 15, 2023 Asad (son): Killed in a UP ST encounter near Jhansi on April 13, 2023 Abaan (youngest son): Killed in a road accident in Jhansi on August 6, 2026	OTHER MEMBERS Umar and Ali (sons): Lodged in separate UP jails Azam (son): Pursuing a degree in law from Manipal Shaista Parveen (wife): Absconding; accused in Umesh Pal murder case Zainab (Ashraf's wife): Wanted in Pal murder case Ayesha Noori (sister): Wanted in Pal murder case
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Atiq's youngest son killed in UP accident

Rohit Kumar Singh, Madhumita Ghosh and Kenneth John

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LUCKNOW/JHANSI/PRAYAGRAJ: Abaan Ahmed, 19, the youngest son of slain gangster-turned-politician Atiq Ahmed, was killed in a road accident in Uttar Pradesh's Jhansi district on Thursday while travelling to meet his elder brother, Ali Ahmed, lodged in the Jhansi district jail, police said. Another occupant of the SUV also died, while three others were injured, they said.

Jhansi senior superintendent of police (SP) BRC TS Murthy said police received information about the accident around 10.30 am. Two people died in the accident, while three others sustained injuries. The injured are undergoing treatment," he said.

Officials said witnesses claimed the driver lost control of the speeding SUV while trying to avoid an animal that had strayed onto the highway and a motorcycle, causing the vehicle to crash into a ditch near Khilli village under Poonch police station limits.

According to police, the sec-

ond person killed was identified as Sonu, 25. The injured, including Azam, 28, Mohammad Javed, 30, and Mohammad Umar, 24, all residents of Prayagraj, are being treated at Jhansi Medical College, they said. According to doctors, they suffered fractures but are out of danger.

"One of the injured passengers told us that the vehicle was moving at a very high speed and became uncontrollable before crashing into the divider," Murthy said. Police have seized the damaged SUV and said CCTV footage from along the highway will be examined as part of the investigation.

The accident marks another tragedy for Atiq Ahmed's family. Atiq and his brother Ashraf Ahmed were shot dead at point-blank range in Prayagraj on April 15, 2023, while being escorted by police for a medical examination. Two days earlier on April 13, Atiq's son Asad Ahmed, wanted in the Umesh Pal murder case, was killed in a police encounter near Jhansi.

Atiq's wife, Shaista Parveen, remains absconding in the Umesh Pal murder case.

MINOR RAPED, KILLED IN M.P.; ACCUSED HELD

NARSINGHPUR: An eight-year-old girl was allegedly abducted, raped and murdered in Madhya Pradesh's Narsinghpur district, police said on Thursday, adding that the accused has been arrested.

The incident was reported in Goteegaon police station limits on Wednesday. Narsinghpur superintendent of police (SP), Rishikesh Meena, said the girl was reported missing at around 5 pm on August 5 after she failed to return home from school.

The SP said the accused took the girl on his motorcycle from outside her school to a dense forest, where he raped her. When the child resisted and screamed, he first tried to strangle her, then threw her into a nearby stream, from where her body was recovered, the SP said. AGENCIES

KEY ACCUSED IN NETTARU MURDER CASE ARRESTED

NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has arrested a key suspect in the 2022 murder of Karnataka BJP leader Praveen Nettaru, the agency said on Thursday.

Ummar Farook MR, who had been absconding and had an Interpol red notice against him, was caught from Kochi on Wednesday following a targeted operation based on credible intelligence inputs, NIA said.

The federal agency had already charged Farook for conspiring to kill Nettaru. Nettaru, BJP Yuv Morcha's Dakshina Kannada district secretary, was hacked to death with sharp weapons in a brutal attack on July 26, 2022, by members of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI). HT

Apex court hopeful of amicable resolution in Sunjay Kapur case

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday recorded that mediation in the high-stakes inheritance dispute within the family of late businessman Sunjay Kapur was progressing satisfactorily and that the warring factions had agreed to explore the possibility of "crystallising a holistic settlement of their claims", even as it reminded them to participate in the process with an "open mind and open heart".

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran took on record a preliminary mediation report submitted by former Chief Justice of India DY Chandrachud, who was appointed by the court in May to facilitate an amicable resolution of the dispute involving the Kapur family trust and its assets. "We are happy to note that the

THE TOP COURT TOOK ON RECORD THE MEDIATION REPORT SUBMITTED BY THE FORMER CJI IN THE MATTER

mediation is proceeding quite satisfactorily. We are also happy to note that the parties concerned are cooperating," said the bench after noting that six mediation sessions had already been conducted.

According to the report, the parties have held detailed discussions regarding their respective claims and entitlements arising out of the trust structure and the assets forming part of its corpus.

It further recorded that the parties agreed to continue discussions under the mediator's

supervision to explore the possibility of "crystallising a holistic settlement of their claims".

The court also noted that the mediator had enlisted the assistance of a senior chartered accountant and a tax expert during the mediation process. Accepting Chandrachud's request for additional time, the bench permitted mediation to continue till November 2.

"We are sure and very much hopeful that the manner in which the parties have cooperated so far in the mediation proceedings, all disputes may get resolved amicably," said the bench, reiterating its earlier advice that the parties should approach mediation with an "open mind and open heart" instead of allowing the dispute to descend into days of litigation.

"Let the mediation proceed further. We shall wait for one more report of the learned mediator."

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Govt opposes plea on income-based quota for SC, ST and OBCs

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NEW DELHI: The Union government on Thursday opposed a plea in the Supreme Court seeking an income-based sub-quota within reserved categories, contending that the constitutional architecture of reservations for Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs) and Other Backward Classes (OBCs) is founded on historical and social disadvantage and cannot be restructured solely on the basis of economic criteria.

The Centre also opposed extending the 'creamy layer' principle to SCs and STs, arguing that Supreme Court precedent has consistently confined the doctrine to Other Backward Classes (OBCs).

In a counter affidavit filed through the department of social justice and empowerment, the Centre argued that the petitions seek judicial directions to redesign the country's reservation policy—a matter that squarely falls within the executive and legislative domain and cannot be commanded by the Supreme Court through a writ of mandamus.

The affidavit has been filed in a batch of petitions by Ramashankar Prajapati, advocate Ashwini Upadhyay, Santa Andolan Samiti and others, who have sought directions to the Centre to introduce income-based preferences within the SC, ST, OBC and Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) categories. They have also sought sub-classification within these categories so that economically weaker persons receive priority in the distribution of reservation benefits.

Rejecting the demand, the Centre maintained that the constitutional scheme under Articles 341, 342 and 342A does not permit alteration of the notified lists of SCs, STs and Socially and Educationally Backward Classes (SEBCs)

IT ALSO OPPOSED EXTENDING THE "CREAMY LAYER" PRINCIPLE TO SCs AND STs, AS TOP COURT PRECEDENT HAS CONSISTENTLY CONFINED THE DOCTRINE TO OBCs

merely on the basis of income.

The identification of SCs, STs and SEBCs based on historical and social criteria such as caste, tribe and social backwardness, and not solely on economic status, maintained the affidavit.

The government explained that the criteria governing these categories have evolved through constitutional provisions, recommendations of commissions such as the Kaka Kalelkar and Mandal Commissions, judicial pronouncements and parliamentary enactments. While economic disadvantage is one of the relevant considerations in identifying backward classes, it is not the sole or determinative criterion, particularly in the case of SCs and STs whose inclusion is rooted in centuries of discrimination, untouchability, social exclusion and geographical isolation.

The affidavit emphasised that Parliament alone has the constitutional authority to amend the Presidential lists of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes under Articles 341(2) and 342(2), and that the courts cannot direct the executive to alter the constitutional framework governing reservation.

On creamy layer, the affidavit relied on the judgments in *Indira Sawhney* (1992), *EV Chinnaihal* (2005), *M Nagaraj* (2006) and *Ashoka Kumar Thakur* (2008), and contended that exclusion based purely on economic advancement would dilute the

very concept of social backwardness on which reservations for SCs and STs are founded.

According to the government, the court in the *Indira Sawhney* case developed the creamy layer principle only in the context of OBC reservations, while the *Ashoka Kumar Thakur* verdict expressly clarified that the doctrine does not automatically extend to SCs and STs. It further argued that the Chinnaihal judgment held that any exclusion from the SC list can only be effected by Parliament and not through judicial orders or executive action. Likewise, the Centre submitted that the Nagaraj judgment did not lay down that creamy layer exclusion applies to SCs and STs.

The affidavit, however, pointed out that outside the sphere of reservations in education and public employment, many welfare schemes for SCs, STs and OBCs already employ means tests and income criteria to ensure that benefits reach the most deserving sections.

It argued that introducing income-based preferences within reservation would require an extensive empirical study of socio-economic data relating to beneficiaries across reserved categories, and cannot be undertaken through judicial directions in proceedings under Article 32.

Describing the petitions as "misconceived", the Centre submitted that they raise non-enforceable constitutional or fundamental rights issue warranting the Supreme Court's intervention. Instead, it said, the petitioners are effectively seeking directions to compel the government to frame a particular policy—a course that falls outside the scope of judicial review.

The Centre urged the Supreme Court to dismiss the petitions. The batch of matters is likely to come up for hearing on August 18.

MEHBOOBA, HER DAUGHTER ILTIJA BOOKED FOR 'ASSAULTING' COPS

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SRINAGAR: Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) chief Mehbooba Mufti and her daughter Iltiya Mufti have been booked for allegedly assaulting police personnel during the party's protest over the abrogation of Article 370 on August 4 in Jammu and Kashmir's Srinagar, an officer said on Thursday.

The FIR has been registered under sections of 132, 121, 191(2) of the BNS at Kothi Bagh police station. "PDP workers led by Mehbooba Mufti and Iltiya Mufti started moving towards the main road. Police requested them not to assemble on the main road. Instead, they turned aggressive and attacked the policemen," the FIR mentioned.

PDP issued a statement saying FIR by city police against Mehbooba Mufti and Iltiya Mufti "is a blatant misuse of power and authority."

2 TRIBALS ABDUCTED, GANG-RAPED IN ASSAM; 3 ARRESTED

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SILCHAR: Three men from Assam's Cachar district have been arrested for allegedly abducting two tribal girls from Mizoram and gang-raping them in a moving car, police said on Thursday.

Additional superintendent of police (crime) Rajat Pal, Cachar district said on August 3, around 2.30 am, the girls arrived at the Dhola police station and reported the incident. They said that the accused raped them. Since both of them claimed to be minors, we proceeded with the matter under the Juvenile Justice system," Police said a case was registered under sections 70(2) (gang rape) a female minor under 18 years of age) and 87 (abduction) of the BNS, along with PoCS Act.

{ ₹3.25L-CRORE DEAL }

France responds to LOR on Rafale jets

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NEW DELHI: France has responded to a letter of request (LOR) sent by the defence ministry with a techno-commercial offer for 114 Rafale fighter jets to sharpen the Indian Air Force's combat edge, marking the next step in a deal expected to be worth ₹3.25 lakh crore, officials aware of the matter said on Thursday.

The French government submitted its proposal to the defence ministry on July 29, paving the way for negotiations on the government-to-government deal to begin, the officials said. India sent the LOR in May, as HT previously reported.

In February, the Defence



This marks the next step in a deal expected to be worth ₹3.25 lakh crore.

Acquisition Council (DAC)—India's apex military procurement body—cleared the purchase of military hardware worth ₹3.6 lakh crore, including 114 Rafale jets under the MRFA (multi-role fighter aircraft) programme. The council's acceptance of the necessity for new fighters was the first step in the

procurement process.

Under the MRFA model being considered, the Rafales will be made in India by French plane maker Dassault Aviation and a local partner. France is expected to supply 20 Rafale jets in fly-away condition while the remaining will be made in India. Discussions have been held with France regarding the localisation of the Rafales to be manufactured in India, the integration of local weapons and other India-specific requirements.

Quicker induction of fighter jets, mid-air refuelers, and airborne early warning and control (AEW&C) systems topped the recommendations an empowered committee made last year for enhancing the IAF's capability. The air force has around 30

Man held for trying to open emergency exit on Kochi-bound flight

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KOCHI: A passenger was arrested for allegedly attempting to open the emergency exit of a Kuala Lumpur-Kochi flight, damaging its window panel and threatening fellow passengers and cabin crew, police said on Thursday.

The accused was identified as Jamsheer Athanikkal, who was travelling on Batik Air flight OD231 from Kuala Lumpur to Kochi on Wednesday.

According to the FIR, the incident occurred between 9.30 pm and 11.05 pm while the aircraft was in flight.

The FIR alleged that Athanikkal tried to force open the aircraft's emergency exit, damaged its window panel and threatened fellow passengers, thereby endangering the safety of those on board. Police said he has

JAMSHEER ATHANIKKAL WAS TRAVELLING ON BATIK AIR FLIGHT OD231 FROM KUALA LUMPUR TO KOCHI ON WEDNESDAY

been booked under Section 351(3) of the BNS for criminal intimidation, Section 11A of the Aircraft Act for violating safety or security directions, and Section 118(e) of the Kerala Police Act for acts endangering public safety.

Jamsheer Athanikkal, an Indian national from Palakkad district, allegedly damaged a window panel inside the aircraft during the flight. After landing, he was taken into custody.— the CIAL said.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS

Hindustan Times

NUMBER THEORY

Everyone has an explanation for the world's biggest events. **Number Theory** tests those explanations against the evidence. Through rigorous analysis, data and fact-based reporting, it uncovers surprising insights, challenges conventional wisdom and reveals the bigger picture behind the issues shaping India and the world.

What is the actual economic inequality in India?

By Roshan Kishore and Abhishek Jha

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Indians to cut down on gold purchases and foreign travel amid concerns over India's external balance, he was subtly hinting towards a deeper problem in the Indian economy. There is now a significant cohort of Indians whose lifestyle is at par with the rich in high-income countries and who are way ahead of how ordinary Indians earn and spend. This cohort seems to have become bigger over time, as is seen in India's rising trade deficit after economic reforms. But, statistically economic reforms, how does one square this (counter-intuitive statistical) circle on inequality? Let us begin with the numbers themselves.

1 The really-rich have seen the lowest increase in spending after reforms

India's first income survey is in the process of being conducted. Existing estimates of inequality are based on consumption expenditure surveys (CES) conducted by the National Statistical Office (NSO). Comparing the monthly per capita expenditure (MPCE) of the entire CES, top 10%, top 5% and top 1% between 1993-94 and 2023-24 CES reveals – the earliest and latest after 1991 reforms – shows that top 1% have seen the lowest proportionate increase in their MPCE. The catch up of the masses vis-a-vis the classes is almost entirely a result of the former's high growth in non-food spending.

Consumption growth between 2023-24 & 1993-94

Chart shows ratio of Monthly Per Capita Expenditure between 2023-24 and 1993-94

Category	Top 1%	Top 5%	Top 10%	All classes
Total	11.1	12.9	13.6	15.3
Food	10.7	10.5	10.6	11.2
Non-Food	11.3	14.6	15.9	21.6

2 Inequality seems to have fallen even within the rich

Thanks to the trend described above, India's consumption inequality has fallen in the post-reform period. The Gini coefficient – the most widespread statistical measure of inequality where 0 shows perfect equality and 1 perfect inequality – has fallen from 0.32 in 1993-94 to 0.29 in 2023-24. What about inequality within the really rich though? It makes sense to ask this question because it is eminently likely that the super-rich (those who own the rich (say, those who own a car) and only the former has seen income rise. Data seems to suggest otherwise once again. Intra-class Gini has seen the sharpest fall among the richest classes between 1993-94 and 2023-24.

Within-class Gini coefficient of MPCE

Category	Top 1%	Top 5%	Top 10%	Overall
1993-94	0.28	0.24	0.23	0.33
2023-24	0.15	0.17	0.18	0.29

3 Is the CES data just counter-intuitive or really not representative?

This is the crux of the debate around India's official inequality estimate. If the CES does not underestimate inequality, going deeper into the data buttresses theories of the survey undercounting the really rich. For example, the most expensive vehicle bought by a household in the 2023-24 household consumption expenditure survey (HCES) cost just Rs 45 lakh. The share of such households in the HCES is eight households per million. This does not really seem to fit consumption standard of India's super rich. For example, according to the Ministry of Road Transport, Vishnu Ishwari, 4,128 Jaguar, 877 Porsche, 52 Maserati, 11 McLaren, and six Aston Martin four wheelers were registered in the country in FY 2023-24, makers that typically sell cars priced significantly above Rs 45 lakh in India. This non-exhaustive count of 5,205 registrations amounts to a share of 16 households per million using population projections and household size from the HCES. The CES might be undercounting the rich at a wider level than just luxury cars. The share of households/population who spent on air travel in 2011-12 and 2023-24 shows a decline from 649 households/75 people per million to 471 households/609 people per million. The number of domestic air passengers in India increased from 68.6 million to 153.7 million during this period, according to the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), which translates to roughly 49,993 departures per million and 1,30,381 departures per million people in 2011-12 and 2023-24 respectively. This means that the average Indian air traveller would have to take 230 trips in 2024-25 instead of 65 in 2011-12 annually for the 16.25 data to be correct.

Domestic air passengers and estimated air travellers

Domestic air passengers per million people: DGCA

Estimated air travellers per million people: CES/HCS

Year	Domestic air passengers (per million people)	Estimated air travellers (per million people)
2011-12	774.8	49,993.26
2023-24	469.04	110,390.58

If the CES is undercounting air travellers, can it be trusted to represent people spending on even higher value goods and services? And if the super rich are undercounted, how credible are its estimates of economic inequality? This does not, however, mean the CES is a useless statistical database. Sure, it tends to undercount the rich, but it also gives a treasure trove of information on the economic condition of a vast majority of Indians. The numbers above only tell us that one should take the inequality measures from the CES data with some amount of skepticism.

LOOK FOR NUMBER THEORY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

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FCRA bill debate likely on Aug 12: Mizoram CM

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
and Neeraj Chauhan
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NEW DELHI: Mizoram chief minister Lalduhoma met Union home minister Amit Shah on Thursday to discuss the concerns of church representatives about the proposed Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, saying later that he was assured that the legislation will not apply retrospectively.

Lalduhoma—who was accompanied by a delegation of senior Christian leaders, including representatives from the Council of Churches in Mizoram (CCM) and the Mizoram Kohhran Hruaitute Committee (MKHC), who submitted a memorandum to Shah—also said the bill was likely to be taken up on August 12.

"We raised six issues with him. Out of six, we were assured that this bill will not have retrospective effect. As for the remaining points we raised, he said he would respond to them in writing and send us his comments. We will have a clear picture only after we receive that reply..." Lalduhoma said after the meeting.

Shah also met Christian leaders who expressed their concerns over the law. Earlier, the Catholic Bishops' Conference of India had expressed their concerns over the provisions in the new foreign funding law and rules. CBCI had said that provisions "could affect charitable institutions that have served poor and vulnerable communities for decades". It also sought safeguards to ensure that existing rights, legally acquired assets and ongoing charitable activities are protected, and called for independent judicial oversight in FCRA-related cases.

Church representatives and NGOs have expressed concern over the provision that allows the government to take control of



Home minister Amit Shah and Mizoram CM Lalduhoma

their permanent assets, such as schools, hospitals, and land that has been purchased with foreign donations—if their FCRA licence lapses.

Under the new law, if an organisation doesn't renew its FCRA licence or it is cancelled, and they continue to use a premises (made out of foreign funds), then it can be vested with the designated authority. NGOs are the assets created for social work by them over the years, if their licence is not renewed, may be taken away by the government.

Though the government has clarified that the Designated Authority manages only assets created from foreign contributions, and only once an organisation's registration has lawfully ceased. Vesting is initially provisional, with full restoration if registration is renewed, and places of worship retain their religious character by law in all cases. The orders of the Authority are subject to revision and to appeal before the Court of the District Judge, the government has said.

In the memorandum to Shah, the Mizoram delegation said the reference to "proselytisation" in fiscal regulations, without a clear and precise definition, created uncertainty for organisations engaged in legitimate social, educational, and faith-based work.

"We respectfully submit that foreign contribution laws should remain focused on fiscal transparency and national security, and therefore recommend that

the term be omitted. Its presence in financial regulations risks unintended misinterpretation and could inadvertently cast doubt on lawful welfare activities carried out by voluntary organisations," it said.

The letter also said that the law must explicitly safeguard voluntary religious activities, moral education, and humanitarian work, all of which are protected under the Constitution.

"The Government of Mizoram, together with the church leadership and civil institutions of the State, remains fully committed to upholding the sovereignty, integrity, and constitutional values of India. At the same time, we urge the law to incorporate these clarifications and safeguards into the FCA framework. Doing so will ensure that the law remains fair, proportionate and consistent with the constitutional principles," the memorandum said.

The group asked for the law to draw a clear distinction between serious violations and minor administrative lapses, proven anti-national activities or wilful financial fraud.

On July 5, Meghalaya CM Conrad Sangma had also met Shah, asking to withdraw the bill as it may have a negative impact on Christian institutions.

Mizoram is 87% Christian and Meghalaya is 74% Christian. The monsoon session of Parliament is scheduled to close on August 13.

The Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 was introduced in the Lok Sabha in the previous session but was not brought for passing after protests by the Opposition and controversy in then poll-bound Kerala. The bill had evoked sharp reactions from Opposition leaders, particularly Kerala lawmakers, as Christian groups alleged they might be targeted under the new law.

₹23k-cr plan to boost compressed biogas production gets cabinet nod

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Thursday approved a ₹23,731 crore national scheme to accelerate domestic Compressed Biogas (CBG) production, strengthen energy security and promote rural livelihoods by converting organic waste into clean fuel.

The GOBARdhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) scheme—the national circular bioenergy scheme—will be implemented from the financial year FY27 to FY36, the government said in a release. Administered by the ministry of petroleum and natural gas, it seeks to

convert agricultural residue, cattle dung, sugar industry waste, municipal organic waste and other biomass into compressed biogas and organic manure to enhance rural income.

The Centre said the scheme is expected to increase domestic CBG production nearly ten-fold, attract large private investment and reduce India's dependence on imported fossil fuels.

Suresh NS, senior research scientist with Strategic Initiatives Group at CSTEP, said, "The scheme will be a major boost for compressed biogas production and can help strengthen India's energy security. The scheme can turn rural and urban organic

waste into useful resources and produce methane for cleaner transport and cooking, while also improving waste management."

Compressed biogas is purified biogas produced from organic waste. After purification, it is chemically similar to natural gas and can be supplied through existing gas pipelines or used as transport fuel in CNG vehicles.

135-km Guwahati-Tezpur corridor cleared

The Union Cabinet on Thursday approved the development of 135.871 km, 4-lane access-controlled Guwahati-Tezpur Corridor of NH-15 in Assam for ₹8,970.20 crore.

HC stays defamation case against Cong president Kharge

CHANDIGARH: The Punjab and Haryana high court has stayed a criminal defamation case against Congress president, Mallikarjun Kharge, pending before a Sangrur court. The case stems from a complaint by Bhavya Bhardwaj, a resident of Sangrur, claiming that Kharge made defamatory comments about Bajrang Dal, during the campaign for 2023 Karnataka Assembly elections.

Punjab BJP MLA's 'sexist' remark sparks row

CHANDIGARH: A remark by BJP legislator Ashwani Sharma during a discussion on illegal mining triggered a political storm in the Punjab assembly on Thursday, with ruling AAP members accusing him of making a "sexist and insensitive" comment about the birth of a girl child. However, Sharma first defended himself, saying he merely used a phrase commonly heard in the state and had no intention of insulting women.



Ashish Mishra

MAIN LAKHIMPUR ACCUSED DENIED HOMETOWN VISITS

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to further relax the bail conditions of Ashish Mishra, the prime accused in the 2021 Lakhimpur Kheri violence case, rejecting his plea to freely visit his hometown in Uttar Pradesh for family functions.

Mishra, son of former Union minister Ajay Mishra Tend, is currently barred from visiting or staying in Lakhimpur Kheri except to attend trial proceedings. Seeking modification of the court's January 2023 bail order, his counsel said the restriction prevented him from attending family events, including his daughters' birthday.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant dismissed the plea, saying, "We find no ground to entertain this prayer. The application is dismissed."

The court noted that it had granted Mishra temporary relaxations on several occasions, allowing him to visit Lakhimpur during festivals and spend time with his family. However, after the permitted period, he was required to return to Lucknow in accordance with the bail conditions.

The violence dates back to a farmers' protest on October 3, 2020, in which eight people were killed. Mishra was arrested within six days. Police charge sheet said Mishra arrived at the protest site in a Mahindra Thar along with a convoy of vehicles that allegedly ran over four protesting farmers. Enraged protesters then allegedly dragged out and lynched three occupants of the convoy. A journalist died in the violence.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of



THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

NEW DELHI SUNDAY JANUARY 22, 2023

Sunday Hindustan Times

HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead, a beauty queen walks her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himalachal village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out

Natasha Rego

Ammaar Reshi (right) is the author of the children's book Alice and Sparkle (above). Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

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PLANT-BASED MEAT

meat rely on microbial engineering: inserting the gene into bacteria or yeast and growing it in bioreactors, the method Impossible Foods uses to make its soy-derived "leghemoglobin." This experiment instead put the gene to work inside a living crop.

Researchers used a device nicknamed a "gene gun" to fire copies of the myoglobin gene — cloned from pigs and cattle — directly into the chloroplasts of tobacco and lettuce seedlings. Chloroplasts are the compartments inside plant cells that carry out photosynthesis; unlike most of a plant's genetic material, they carry their own small, separate genome — a relic of their origins as free-living bacteria billions of years ago.

Due to their bacterial ancestry and their high number of copies per cell, chloroplasts are generally much better at making large amounts of protein than the cell nucleus," said Dr Alexia Groff, a researcher at Imperial College London and the study's lead author.

To be sure, tobacco isn't edible and none of its myoglobin is headed for a dinner plate — it served as a testing ground. Tobacco's chloroplast genome is among the best understood and easiest to modify of any plant, making it what scientists call a "model" organism, used to prove a technique before attempting it in a food crop.

As Groff put it, tobacco was chosen "because it is the best model plant for developing this technology, and lettuce because it is an edible crop that could eventually be used for food ingredient production."

The engineered seedlings grew into normal, fertile plants that flowered and passed the new gene on to their seeds. Measurements found myoglobin yields of roughly 800 mg per kilogram dry weight in tobacco and 810 mg/kg in lettuce — modest next to real meat, which contains 8,100-12,000 mg/kg, but the authors argue crops could ultimately outperform livestock on a per-hectare basis, given far lower water and land demands.

There is, however, a catch that limits the ingredient's usefulness for now: only around 35% of the plant-grown myoglobin was found to have its essential iron-carrying heme

molecule properly attached, compared with 80% for myoglobin made in bacteria. Heme is what actually gives meat its red colour and much of its flavour — a myoglobin protein without it is structurally intact but functionally inert. The researchers say boosting the plant's own heme supply will be key to making the ingredient viable.

"Plants can be engineered to produce the animal protein myoglobin in their chloroplasts, the energy factories for photosynthesis. This could provide a more sustainable way to produce an important ingredient for plant-based meat products," Groff said.

Groff added that the next step would be extracting and purifying the protein using standard industrial methods before it could be blended into existing meat alternatives to improve their colour, flavour and nutritional profile.

Co-author Dr Kyoko Morimoto of Kyomei, which partly funded Groff's doctoral research, suggested a second possible use: "We hope that edible lettuce, modified to express myoglobin, could also one day serve as a heme-iron-rich biofortified food, depending on legislative approval."

TEJPAL SENTENCED

blaming and institutional resistance isolates survivors, prompting them to switch jobs or accept demotions," Justice Gokhale observed.

Tejpal was sentenced to 10 years' rigorous imprisonment and fined ₹5 lakh on each of the two rape convictions under Section 376(2) of the IPC. He was also sentenced to one year's imprisonment under Section 354A, and three years' rigorous imprisonment under Section 354B, besides fines under Sections 341 and 342. All the sentences will run concurrently, meaning Tejpal will serve a maximum of 10 years in prison.

The case stems from allegations that Tejpal raped a junior colleague inside an elevator at a five-star hotel in Goa during the ThinkFest festival in November 2013. The complainant alleged that he raped her on November 7 and sexually assaulted her again the following day.

Following the allegations, Tejpal resigned as editor of Tehelka

and sent an email to staff describing the episode as a "shameful lapse of judgement," though he did not specifically admit to the allegations.

A fast-track court acquitted Tejpal on May 21, 2021, giving him the benefit of doubt and holding that there was insufficient evidence to convict him. The Goa government challenged the acquittal before the High Court.

Speaking to reporters outside court, Tejpal said he would challenge Thursday's verdict in the Supreme Court.

"We are going to appeal against the verdict. We are very disappointed. We believe the evidence in the case has not been appreciated. We believe there is enough evidence to very clearly exonerate me," he said.

Tejpal also alleged that he was being politically targeted because of his journalism, comparing his case to that of former JNU scholar Umar Khalid, who has been in jail since 2020 in the Delhi riots conspiracy case under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and whose bail has repeatedly been denied.

"I told the judge that I'm a political victim. I'm a journalist from Tehelka. The government has been after me for the past 13 years... We will appeal this in the Supreme Court," he said.

Goa Advocate General Devdas Pangam welcomed the verdict, calling it a case of "justice being done." He said Tejpal had occupied a position of trust as the complainant's employer and criticised the manner in which the complainant had been cross-examined during the trial.

"The facts are so gross. He was a father figure. He was a friend of the father of the victim. He was the employer of the victim. Despite that he has done this," Pangam said.

He also said the trial court's findings had unfairly questioned the complainant's character. "The order of the trial court was completely bad. The trial court's order was completely maligning the victim's character. The observations made by the court to say that the victim was in consent as regards these acts are perverse," he said.

Investigating officer Superintendent of Police Sunita Sawant said the verdict would encourage women across workplaces to stand up for their rights.

"This judgment is very important for women who are working

in all sectors — private, government, all the sectors," she said. The trial began in September 2017 but was delayed after Tejpal challenged the framing of charges before the High Court and the Supreme Court. The Supreme Court directed that the trial be completed by December 2020, later extending the deadline because of the Covid-19 pandemic. Proceedings resumed in 2019 and were thereafter conducted on a day-to-day basis.

Before the High Court, the prosecution argued that the trial court had effectively put the complainant on trial instead of the accused. Appearing for the state, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta contended that the complainant's testimony had been unfairly used against her and that the trial court had discarded her evidence despite a clear and consistent account of sexual assault, rape, criminal force and wrongful confinement.

The state also argued that the acquittal rested on stereotypical assumptions about how a survivor of sexual assault is expected to behave.

The defence, on the other hand, argued that inconsistencies in the complainant's statements and her conduct after the alleged assaults undermined the prosecution's case. It relied on CCTV footage, photographs, WhatsApp messages, emails and witness testimony to contend that she continued to participate in ThinkFest events, attended social gatherings and appeared at case after the incidents.

The defence also argued that the complainant had called Tejpal to join her for a photograph with Hollywood actor Robert De Niro, which, it said, was inconsistent with the prosecution's claim that she was fearful of him.

RS CHAIR'S COMMENT

late finance minister Arun Jaitley's notion that disruption was a part of parliamentary democracy.

"But here, when we are asking genuine questions, they are escaping," Kharge said. Afterward, the chairman turned to Rijju.

"Now I request you to consider his [Kharge's] request. He requested the home minister to come to the House. As parliamentary affairs minister, you can echo the sentiments of the Opposition to the HM," Radhakrishnan said.

The term "conveying the

sentiments" in parliamentary proceedings is widely regarded as sending a signal to the minister or a member from the top office of the House. It is not binding on the member but usually, a member acts accordingly to the larger sense of the House.

Radhakrishnan also mentioned "it is his will" indicating that ultimately it would be Shah's decision whether to respond to the Opposition's demand.

To be sure, Shah is expected to reply to the debate on the Proposed Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which Mizoram chief minister Laldulhoma's statement came after meeting Shah in Delhi.

Radhakrishnan's direction was preceded by a sharp exchange between Rijju and Kharge. Amid sloganeering during Zero Hour, Rijju said he wanted to draw attention to two rules, Rules 235 (2) and Rule 240, to underline the disruptions by the Opposition.

Rule 235(2) prohibits any member from interrupting another member who was currently speaking. Rijju referred to this rule as the Opposition was preventing speakers from raising issues during Zero Hour.

Rule 240 deals with irrelevance or repetition during parliamentary debates, in a possible reference to Kharge, who has been raising allegations of police excesses against the protestors on July 20.

"Every day Kharge ji reads out the same thing. Kharge ji says the same thing, this Rule applies to our Leader of the Opposition," Rijju said. The Opposition protested against the minister's intervention.

Speaking to reporters outside Parliament, Rijju defended the home minister.

"The home minister and the Prime Minister are present in Parliament from morning until evening. The opposition members themselves do not let the House function; instead, they raise slogans outside. This is not right..."

In the Rajya Sabha, bills are being passed after thorough discussion despite the conflict in West Asia. India has urged the parties involved in the conflict to return to dialogue and diplomacy to find a lasting solution. The Indian side has backed the two-state solution. HTC

AGNI-4 BALLISTIC MISSILE FIRED SUCCESSFULLY

NEW DELHI: India on Thursday successfully test-fired nuclear-capable ballistic missile Agni-4 from the integrated test range in Odisha's Chandipur, demonstrating its strategic strike capabilities.

The testing of the missile was carried out by the Strategic Forces Command (SFC) and the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO). "Medium Range Ballistic Missile 'Agni-4' was successfully test-fired from the Integrated Test Range, Chandipur in Odisha on August 6," the defence ministry said.

The launch validated all operational and technical parameters. The test was carried out under the aegis of the Strategic Forces Command, it said.

Defence minister Rajnath Singh congratulated the DRDO and the SFC on the successful test-firing of the Agni-4 missile. "I congratulate SFC and DRDO for this test mission launch which reaffirmed India's commitment to defend the nation with state of the art technologies," he said on X. PH

PARL PANEL FOR EARLY CONCLUSION OF U.S. TRADE PACT

NEW DELHI: A parliamentary panel has suggested the government to conclude the proposed bilateral trade agreement (BTA) with the US at the earliest while ensuring that India's interests are adequately protected.

A report of the department related parliamentary standing committee on commerce on 'Evaluation of India-US Trade Relations', said the government should negotiate for complete exemption for India's key export products such as generic medicines, critical minerals and smartphones from any future unexpected US tariff increases.

It suggested that the Department of Commerce should also prepare a time-bound roadmap to achieve the objectives of the Mission 500 initiative by promoting trade in goods and services, encouraging investment, enhancing cooperation in critical technologies, improving supply chain and addressing both tariff and non-tariff barriers faced by Indian exporters. The two countries have set a goal to more than double total bilateral trade to \$500 billion by 2030. PH



Capt Amarinder my favourite BJP leader: Rahul

NEW DELHI: In an "Ask Me Anything" (AMA) that Rahul Gandhi did on Instagram on Thursday, he was asked a question about his favourite Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader to which he replied that he really liked Captain Amarinder Singh "He's cool, I get along with him. And he's an expert on military history." He also added, "Hello, Uncle Amarinder." This comes just ahead of Punjab polls when the party's state unit has been struggling with infighting between Raja Warring and Charanjit Singh Channi.

Yusuf Pathan flags mosque loudspeaker removal in WB distt

NEW DELHI: Trinamool Congress (TMC) MP Yusuf Pathan and two other party MPs from West Bengal have submitted a memorandum to Union home minister Amit Shah, seeking his "urgent intervention" on the removal of loudspeakers from mosques in Murshidabad district by police. In a memorandum also flags the delay in deciding pending Electoral Photo Identity Card (EPIC) tribunals cases.

TN CM Vijay writes to PM Modi over river-link project

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to take up the Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar Link project on a fast track basis and demanded that the project be declared as of "national importance." Its early execution would benefit the people and farming communities of Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka," the CM said in a letter to PM Modi.

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Sugar mills to start crushing early to ease festive season supply

Pallavi Singhal
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NEW DELHI: Following discussions with the Centre, sugar mills will begin crushing sugarcane 10-15 days earlier than usual in the 2026-27 sugar season to bring fresh sugar into the market ahead of the festive season, according to a letter issued by the Indian Sugar & Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) and the National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories Ltd (NFCSP) to the department of food and public distribution on Thursday.

The industry has, however, sought government support—including cancellation for lower sugar recovery, a temporary waiver of the Centre's share of Central GST and a higher domestic sales quota—to offset losses from processing immature cane, saying mills were undertaking early crushing "in larger public interest". The move comes as sugar prices continue to climb despite a series of government steps.

Average retail sugar prices touched a record ₹50 per kg on Thursday, up nearly 9% from a year ago and 7% over the past month. The Centre has imposed stockholding limits on dealers,

ordered physical verification of stocks at mills and extended an export ban through September in a bid to cool prices.

In the joint letter, the ISMA and the NFCSP said India had sufficient sugar stocks to meet domestic demand and there was "no cause for concern" over availability. Asked why mills needed to start crushing early if stocks were adequate, ISMA director general Deepak Ballani said it was "a preventive step to reinforce supply" before the festive season.

A senior sugar industry executive, speaking on condition of anonymity, said traders estimate closing stocks at around 3.5 mt.

With October consumption expected at about 2.4 mt, stocks could fall to just 1.1 mt by month-end, creating supply tightness in western and southern India. If much of the inventory remains concentrated in UP, the executive said, adding that processing immature cane reduces sugar recovery and yields, potentially lowering 2026-27 production and creating supply pressure by May-June 2027. To offset losses, the industry has asked the Centre to allow immediate sale of October's additional sugar output. The ministry is yet to release a statement.

[ONLINE CONTENT TAKEDOWN ORDERS]

SC stays pleas in HCs against Sahyog portal

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court in a recent order has stayed all pending challenges to the Centre's Sahyog portal pending before two high courts on a petition filed by Centre seeking transfer of these cases to the top court for deciding the constitutional validity of section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology Act dealing with Centre's power to order online content takedown.

In an order passed on July 22, made public recently, a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant issued notice on the Centre's plea and posted the matter for further consideration on August 10.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta who represented the Centre urged the court to stay the proceedings before the high courts of Karnataka and Bombay which are hearing petitions on the same issue.

The bench, also comprising justices Jaymylia Bagchi and V Mohana directed, "Meanwhile, following proceedings before the high courts shall remain stayed." These proceedings include cases filed by X Corp and Digipub News India Foundation pending in the Karnataka high court, and peti-



SC posted the matter for further hearing on August 10.

tions filed by comedian Kunal Kamra and Hareesh Jagtiani in the Bombay high court.

Mehta informed the court that the pendency of the matter in different high courts may result in conflicting verdicts on a common issue.

The stay has come at a time when the Bombay HC had proceeded with the hearing of the matter and had directed Centre to file a response before the next date of hearing on August 14.

The Sahyog portal was developed by the Ministry of Home Affairs as a common platform to communicate government's takedown orders to intermediaries.

The petitions had claimed before the high courts that such a measure by the Centre did not follow the due process and the checks prescribed by the Supreme Court in the Shrey Singhal case of 2015.



Darshan

RENUKASWAMY MURDER CASE: 3 ACCUSED SEEK APPROVER STATUS

Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: Three accused in the Renukaswamy murder case have approached a Bengaluru sessions court seeking to turn approvers, a move that could strengthen the prosecution's case if they are allowed to testify against the remaining accused, including Kannada actor Darshan, people aware of the matter said.

Pradosh Rao, the first to file the motion on Tuesday, was followed by Wendaray by Ravi Shankar and Vinay Raghavendra alias Vinay, whose lawyers told the court that they were willing to become prosecutive witnesses.

"After hearing arguments, the 59th Additional City Civil and Sessions Court reserved its order till August 10 on whether objections raised by the co-accused can be considered at this stage," a senior investigator said on condition of anonymity.

Special public prosecutor Prasanna Kumar said the state had no objection to the applications. Darshan's counsel Hashmat Pasha opposed the plea, saying pardon cannot be granted merely because an accused agrees to testify.

HEALTH MINISTRY NOTIFIES STRICTER DRUG RULES

Rhythmka Kaul
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NEW DELHI: The Union health ministry has amended the Drugs Rules, 1945, to empower licensing authorities to debar pharmaceutical companies that submit fake or fabricated data while seeking regulatory approvals for drugs, in a move aimed at strengthening the integrity and transparency of India's drug regulatory system.

The ministry said the amendments, notified through GS R 756(E), introduce a new enforcement mechanism in addition to the existing provisions under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940.

Until now, companies found submitting fabricated data could face rejection of applications or cancellation of licences. Under the amended rules, such entities can also be barred from filing fresh applications with the concerned state or central licensing authority for a specified period.

"In addition to existing enforcement provisions under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, these newly notified provisions empower the Licensing Authority to debar further applications by entities who submit fake or fabricated data," the ministry said in a statement.

It further said a show-cause notice will be issued before any punitive action is taken and applicants will have the right to appeal. The ministry said the amendments are intended to deter misconduct, strengthen accountability among applicants and ensure that approvals of drugs are backed by reliable and scientifically valid evidence.

ED books ex-Kotak bank exec, eight others in MC funds case

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

PANCHKULA: Tightening its grip on the alleged siphoning of municipal corporation (MC) Panchkula funds, the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) has filed a prosecution complaint against nine accused under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) in Panchkula court and attached assets worth ₹131.3 crore, claiming to have secured 100% of the embezzled civic funds within four months of the registration of the FIR.

The action stems from the multi-crore Kotak Mahindra Bank fraud case, in which ED is probing the laundering of ₹107.24 crore allegedly siphoned off from MC Panchkula through unauthorised bank accounts.

According to ED, the investigation revealed that Pushpinder Singh, then deputy vice president of Kotak Mahindra Bank, in connivance with MC official Vikas Kaushik and bank employee Dilip Raghav, opened two unauthorised bank accounts in the name of MC

ED CLAIMED THAT SINGH USED THE PROCEEDS OF CRIME TO ACQUIRE ASSETS LIKE PORSCHE, CAYENNE, 3 BMW CARS, LAND CRUISER AND HARLEY-DAVIDSON

Panchkula using forged documents and fake authorisation letters. Funds from the corporation's genuine accounts were allegedly diverted into these accounts by bypassing the bank's standard operating procedures.

The agency alleged that mobile numbers and email IDs linked to both the fake and genuine MC accounts were altered to those controlled by the accused, allowing fraudulent transactions to be executed without triggering the bank's internal checks.

The siphoned money was allegedly layered through several intermediaries, including Rajat Dahra,

Swati Tomar, Kapil Kumar, Vinod Kumar and Sonni, besides firms such as SK Agrotech and SK Agro-firm, before being routed into personal accounts and investments.

ED claimed that Pushpinder Singh used the proceeds of crime to acquire luxury assets, including a Porsche Cayenne, BMW 740Li, BMW X7, BMW Z4, Land Cruiser, Harley-Davidson motorcycles and Jeep Wrangler SUVs. Investigators also alleged that after the fraud surfaced, he sold some vehicles and transferred Sector-2 properties in Panchkula to his sister through funds routed via a company owned by his wife, Preeti Thakur, to try to conceal ownership and prevent attachment.

The investigation further found that part of the allegedly diverted money was advanced as unsecured loans to individuals and private entities at an interest rate of 3% per month in cash.

Under a Provisional Attachment Order, ED has attached bank balances worth ₹12.85 crore and immovable properties valued at ₹18.28 crore, taking the total attachment to ₹131.3 crore.

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OPINION

The
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{ OUR TAKE }

Partitioning a party's legacy

The top court should catalyse the formation of rules on defections and determining majority

At the heart of the many dubious political manoeuvres that have blighted India's democracy in recent years is the question — what is the real political party in case of a defection or a split, and who gets to lay claim to the original name and symbol? Unfortunately, a lack of clearly defined parameters has encouraged multiple controversial ad-hoc decisions affecting the futures of major parties such as the Shiv Sena (more than once), the Nationalist Congress Party and, possibly, the Trinamool Congress. Now, the Supreme Court appears poised to intervene and clarify this confusion. A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joyymala Bagchi and V Mohana observed that there must be clearly defined criteria to determine the majority in a political party when rival factions stake claim to its name and election symbol, indicating that such disputes cannot be resolved solely on the basis of the numerical strength of legislators.

This is welcome. The court is correct in noting that there should be defined criteria to determine the concept of "majority", needing a more nuanced and thorough examination than merely counting legislators. Such guidelines can come either from a political party's constitution itself, or evolve through wide consultations held by the ECI. After all, despite multiple defections and splits, the concept of a majority has not been adequately clarified, leading to a situation where respective speakers or chairpersons of Houses have massive discretionary powers. As a result, adjudication on splits and defections is now a politicised affair, leading to Opposition allegations that the ruling dispensation always has an upper hand.

HT has noted repeatedly that a toothless anti-defection law has done little to stem the tide of political defections. At the same time, many political parties — run as personal fiefs and tightly controlled by families or personalities — have throttled internal democracy and ensured that party committees and constitutions are mere rubber-stamps that exist to further the agenda of the party supremo. Unfortunately, India's sharply polarised polity doesn't hold out much hope of a consultative process where parties can collectively come up with such guidelines. The Supreme Court should consider stepping in at the earliest and catalyse the formation of uniform and transparent rules to govern defections, the determination of a majority, and the adjudication of the recipient of party names and symbols. Such a step can dispel some of the chaos engulfing India's political system today.

Trust in E20 fuel needs transparency

Complaints about E20 petrol, mandatory at Indian fuel pumps since April, have run for months. The disquiet has been largely on social media, but in recent weeks, two industry letters have given it technical weight. On July 24, petrol pump dealers wrote to the Centre saying they can test dispensed fuel only for density and water paste — alluding to an inability to test for humidity that has become a unique Achilles heel for fuel stocks that can spoil. Days later, the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) flagged chloride and moisture contamination as damaging vehicle components, then withdrew the letter within hours of it becoming public, citing a need to authenticate the readings. The government has answered by pointing to monitoring already in place — monitoring both parties describe as inadequate.

Criticism of ethanol-blended fuel has long centred on ethanol itself — that it drops mileage, saps power, and corrodes interiors. The new letters make a different case. Ethanol is not the problem; the supply chain from distillation to storage may be introducing contaminants the specification does not screen for and the retail chain cannot detect.

Ethanol blending has a real case on energy security and forex savings. The gaps deserve engagement, not defection. The signals in the two industry communications — even in withdrawal — are serious enough to warrant a closer look at the programme's specification and its retail chain. Some of the political framing around E20 is opportunistic. That does not answer the questions the disclosures now raise: whether the E20 specification is adequate to what millions of vehicles are now being asked to run on; whether the retail chain, limited to density and water-paste testing, can catch what the specification does not; and why an industry body wrote a technical letter one day and walked it back the next.

No news content for AI training without licences

Large language model developers would be well advised to proceed with caution and to not violate copyright protections on the basis of misconceived interpretations of the Delhi HC's interim order in *ANI vs. OpenAI*

The Delhi High Court's interim order in *ANI Media Pvt. Ltd. v. OpenAI* (2025) refusing injunctive relief, may be a precursor to re-casting India's copyright laws and interpreting existing laws in light of evolving technologies, to ensure transparency and effective balancing of owner rights with that of public interest. Further appeals and developments on this order are inevitable. This, being an interim order, does not decide rights of all large language models (LLMs), but its impact in evaluating the legality of use of copyright-protected content in training and reproductions by LLMs cannot be disputed. This being an interim order, it would be premature for LLM developers to rejoice or assume unfettered usage of publicly available data. For the public, sans technicalities, the relevance lies in continued availability of technology-enabled conveniences. For the copyright owners, this is a wake-up call to strengthen their rights through statutory upgrades and use of technology

to protect their publicly shared proprietary content. A copyright owner's rights over proprietary content restrict third parties from reproducing and communicating to public such content without consent of the owners. Section 14 of the Copyright Act, 1957 (the Act) explicitly restrains "storing" of such data without owner consent. The question of LLMs being trained using copyright-protected content scraped from the web, without consent of the owner of such data, cuts to the root of protections afforded under the Act.

In *ANI v. OpenAI*, the Delhi High Court delves into copyright and LLM fundamentals, and upholds ANI's copyright claims to its news content, along with the reiteration that "original literary works" that are available free of cost and publicly accessible are nevertheless entitled to copyright protection. This is critical to combat rampant plagiarism.

However, where the Delhi High Court based its refusal of injunctive relief is the factual comparison of ANI's claims of violation with actual reproductions by ChatGPT. The HC found the commonalities to be inadequate. The reproductions by ChatGPT cannot be disputed. This being an interim order, it would be premature for LLM developers to rejoice or assume unfettered usage of publicly available data. For the public, sans technicalities, the relevance lies in continued availability of technology-enabled conveniences. For the copyright owners, this is a wake-up call to strengthen their rights through statutory upgrades and use of technology

substantially similar to the copyrighted content, injunctive reliefs will follow, as was the outcome in *GEMA v. OpenAI*, decided in the Regional Court of Munich.

The remaining issues framed and decided at a preliminary stage are the legality of storing proprietary data and "fair use" exemptions. The findings here are most likely to form the basis for an appeal by ANI and any other copyright owner to distinguish from this interim order.

Trends across jurisdictions point to restrictions on misuse of publicly available data, as in the *GEMA* case, and permissibility under fair dealing, including the three-factor test formulated by the HC. Critics, while extensive submissions were made interpreting "derivative" and "transformative" works, the same does not form the basis for the final conclusion of the Court.

Copyright protection under the Act is ringfenced by exemptions under Section 52. Under Section 52(1)(a), "fair dealing of any work", among other things, for "private or personal use, including research" would be non-infringing. The Explanation further qualifies that "storing" in any medium for the purposes of personal use, including research, this provision would not amount to infringement. Section 14, which restricts storing by third parties without licence from owners, has been read with Section 52(1)(a) by the HC to hold that while, in general, "storage" of copyright-protected data is an infringement, it would not be so when it falls within the exemptions. The HC follows the Supreme Court of Canada in *CCI Canadian v. Law Soci-*



NS Nappinai



A final decision in *ANI v. OpenAI* would go a long way in laying down jurisprudence on the intersection of AI and copyrights.

ADDRESS: TROC

ety of Upper Canada, while liberally interpreting the "private or personal use including for research". The court does emphasise that the "research is at the behest of humans and for the benefit of humans", but then fails to clarify how training of human-made technology would qualify under this exemption.

On "fair dealing", the Court formulates a three-factor test to whether OpenAI used ANI's data only for training its LLMs, whether the outcome causes actual or potential damage to the business of ANI, and whether the functions performed by ChatGPT serve public interest. On these, the Court holds that ChatGPT's outputs are distinct from those of ANI and that extracts cannot harm the business prospects of ANI. With respect to the first test, the Court relies on factual findings to hold that Open AI has only used the data for training. The Court's stand with respect to the third test remains tentative as convenience has been confused with public interest. The need to clarify primacy of ownership

rights over convenience, therefore, still remains to be tested by judicial review. Public interest lies in having access to copyright-protected content and not in infringement thereof. Such access can be assured even through licensing, including compulsory licensing in case of hoarding of knowledge.

It remains to be seen which among the many grounds for rejection of injunctive reliefs will sustain further judicial review. A final decision in this case would go a long way in laying down jurisprudence on the intersection of AI and copyrights. Meanwhile, developers would be well advised to proceed with caution and to not violate copyright protections on misconceived interpretations of the HC judgment. Copyright owners need to tighten their technology-enabled protections, while battling for clarity in statutes.

NS Nappinai is senior advocate, Supreme Court, and founder, Cyber Saathi. The views expressed are personal

FIXING EXAMS: SYSTEMIC OR CONSTITUTIONAL REFORMS?

{ SRIDHAR RAJAGOPALAN } EDUCATION ENTREPRENEUR

Move from testing memory to testing understanding

Close on the heels of Dharmendra Pradhan resigning as the Union education minister — after student protests over NEET and CBSE irregularities — the constituted a high-power task force chaired by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani, to overhaul the country's education system. While deploying advanced technology and tightening logistics are essential steps, we risk missing the wood for the trees.

The ongoing crisis is not a sudden failure of administration, but the inevitable outcome of a fundamentally broken architecture. Leaked papers, compromised marking systems, and the desperation of millions are symptoms of an education system that has prioritised rote memorisation over cognitive development for decades.

Tactical interventions such as elite committees, harsher punitive provisions, and bureaucratic shuffling only address the perimeter, not the core. To address the latter, the political class must confront deep-seated resistance and overhaul how we assess our children.

From primary school to secondary board exams, our system rewards the accurate retrieval of textbook information rather than the application of concepts. What has changed over the years — at a glacial pace — is the acceptance that this is the problem. But our exams and our classroom pedagogy have not changed in tandem.

A significant percentage of students in our country struggle to acquire foundational literacy and numeracy. Even in our elite private schools, when we assess for deep understanding, our students perform below the international average. There is a belief that challenging course material and exams are unfair to those who are socially or economically challenged; this has led to the system "compensating" by lowering the cognitive demands of exams, setting in motion a cycle that teaches less and expects less.

This pedagogical gap is directly linked to the desperation that fuels exam syndicates and paper leaks. When an assessment system fails to cultivate genuine problem-solving abilities, the students are left entirely dependent on a narrow battery of competitive exams. Furthermore, because the exams test memory rather than cognitive agility, possessing the question paper beforehand guarantees success. At our exams were designed to evaluate complex reasoning — utilising Item Response Theory and pedagogical research on what concepts students find more and less difficult — even a leaked paper would be of little use to a student who lacks the underlying conceptual framework.

While moving NEET to a multi-stage, computer-based testing system is an obvious recommendation, to truly resolve this crisis, the newly formed task force and policymakers must look beyond cybersecurity and logistics. We need the following structural reforms.

Transforming board examinations: Our board exams must move away from being memory tests. We need a definitive shift toward assessments where questions are designed to test understanding. Today, a student can achieve exceptionally high scores simply by memorising past papers and textbook answers. Until we



design exams where a student must genuinely understand the material to pass, the incentive to cheat or rely on coaching factories will remain insurmountable. We must also benchmark ourselves for improvement by participating in international assessments such as PISA.

Implementing multi-tier assessment architecture: The logistical challenge of securely testing millions of anxious candidates simultaneously puts the entire system under serious strain. A universally accessible, basic qualifying examination can evaluate foundational competencies. Only those who clear this benchmark should proceed to advanced, high-stakes competitive exams. The model meaningfully reduce the administrative burden on testing agencies and diffuse the anxiety that currently defines our exam season.

Leveraging large-scale learning data: We must deploy large-scale learning data tools to track student comprehension long before they reach Class 12 or university entrances. By rigorously evaluating item response parameters and diagnostic metrics throughout a student's lifecycle, we can identify remedial learning gaps early.

Rejecting rushed implementations: We have seen major systemic changes, such as the CUEI, implemented with haste. Meaningful assessment reform is a complex systemic endeavour that requires extensive operational strategy, pilot testing, and rigorous evaluation of parameters. Rushing these changes risks failure and could further erode public trust.

The anger of our youth is entirely understandable. They deserve a system that sets them up to succeed.

A secure exam that tests the wrong things is still only a partial fix. True reform will require expending significant political capital to work through the resistance that any deep change inevitably meets.

Sridhar Rajagopalalan is co-founder, Educational Initiatives. The views expressed are personal

{ P WILSON } LAWYER

Centralised education policy can't deliver true reforms

DR Balamkumar once said, "Examination is something quite different from education, but in the name of raising the standards of education, they are making examinations so impossible and so severe that the backward communities which have hitherto not had the chance of entering the portals of University are absolutely kept out."

The progressive shrinking of states' space in education policy did not begin yesterday. It began with the National Policy on Education of 1968, adopted by the Union Government in the wake of the Kothari Commission, which formalised the three-language formula. Even before that policy took full shape, CN Annadurai, then Tamil Nadu chief minister, spearheaded a historic resolution in January 1968 in the assembly, rejecting the three-language formula in favour of a two-language policy (Tamil and English). That resolution was the institutional expression of a people's determination to protect linguistic identity and educational opportunity. Tamil Nadu has adhered to this policy, delivering high literacy and strong higher-education outcomes.

However, the constitutional reordering effected by the 42nd Amendment — which transferred education from the State List to the Concurrent List — demoted the states' legislative competence. The exclusive domain of the states became a shared field, which the Union increasingly dominated. This set the stage for successive national frameworks that have steadily eroded the autonomy of states to shape education according to their realities.

The National Education Policy 2020 has revived the same pressure under a new guise. Its three-language formula, however flexible it claims to be on paper, is experienced in non-Hindi-speaking states as an instrument of linguistic imposition. When national boards and funding mechanisms push three languages as the default, states that stand by their two-language policy are portrayed as obstructionist. Uniformity is preferred over genuine federal accommodation.

The NEET controversy exposes the same centralising logic. Tamil Nadu's public health system long depended on medical graduates selected through a transparent, state-controlled process that prioritised local needs and social justice, while also fulfilling its constitutional mandate of maintaining public health. Tamil Nadu took the litigation route to keep NEET away since its inception (through regulations promulgated by the Medical Council of India); only in 2016 did the Union government make NEET compulsory nationwide, from 2017.

A single national entrance examination, conducted in a format that privileges coaching-centre culture and urban advantage, has systematically disadvantaged rural and underprivileged students. The Tamil Nadu assembly has twice passed legislation seeking exemption from NEET. The delay in presidential assent and the Union's refusal to amend the National Medical Commission Act demonstrate that while states may legislate, the Union retains an effective veto. The Tamil Nadu government, in fact, had



to file a suit before the Supreme Court challenging the withholding of assent by the President of the state NEET Exemption Bill. A private member's Bill in the Rajya Sabha to make NEET optional for states, introduced by me, awaits meaningful consideration.

The protests at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi and across the country brought the failures of the national examination system into sharp public focus. The agitation saw young people demand accountability and systemic reform. It underscored not just public anger but also the systemic weaknesses and crisis of confidence in centralised testing, which is not confined to one region.

These developments form part of a larger pattern. National testing frameworks, model curricula, and conditional funding increasingly determine what is taught, how admissions are conducted, and which languages are privileged. Cooperative federalism is reduced to after-the-fact consultation. When states assert their constitutional space, they are accused of parochialism. When the Union centralises, it is celebrated as national integration. This asymmetry is unsustainable.

Education policy that ignores regional languages, local knowledge systems and state-specific equity concerns produces alienation. If the space for policy-making by states continues to shrink, even with so-called reforms, we risk a homogenised system that serves neither excellence nor equity. The Union must respect the legislative and executive competence of states in the concurrent domain. National frameworks must remain guiding, not binding. Tamil Nadu will continue to defend its two-language policy and its right to determine medical admissions, not out of defiance, but out of fidelity to the constitutional promise of a diverse Union and the prospect of real reforms. The space for states in education policy-making in education must be restored and protected. Anything less diminishes the future of our children.

P Wilson is a senior advocate and member of Rajya Sabha. The views expressed are personal

Iran threatens to hit Gulf states if US conducts strikes

Reuters

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TEHRAN: Iran has made a concerted diplomatic push with Gulf states, warning them explicitly that Tehran will hit their oil, power and water plants unless they convince Donald Trump to end US strikes on Iran and instead seek a negotiated end to the war.

The warning envisaged attacks on the energy facilities, oil fields, refineries, electricity grids, water infrastructure, transport networks and other strategic assets of Washington's closest Arab allies, according to a senior Iranian official.

The message, part of a broader Iranian effort to deter further US military action by raising the prospect of severe economic disruption across the Gulf, was delivered through a flurry of high-level diplomatic contacts after Trump threatened on July 28 to strike Iran's energy network and infrastructure, the sources said.

Two senior Iranian officials, two Gulf sources and a senior regional diplomat with knowledge of the discussions said Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi spoke with his Saudi, Turkish and Qatari counterparts, as well as Pakistan's army chief.

Araghchi urged Washington's Gulf allies to use their influence with Trump to dissuade him from launching renewed strikes, the senior diplomat said, warning that any attack on Iran would prompt retaliation against US assets and critical infrastructure across the Gulf.

The diplomatic campaign underscores how Iran is seeking to turn Gulf vulnerability into leverage, confronting regional governments with the prospect that any renewed US-Iran confrontation could place the infrastructure underpinning their economies directly in the firing line.

Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman subsequently spoke with Trump, urging him to delay military action, return to



Cargo ships and other commercial vessels anchored in the Strait of Hormuz, off Bandar Abbas coast, Iran.

Houthi kill 38 Saudi-backed Yemeni government forces

DUBAI: Yemen's Iran-backed Houthis killed 38 Saudi-backed government troops in missile and drone attacks on Thursday, medical sources said, the deadliest violence in years between them as the conflict becomes the latest front in the US-Iran war.

Houthi military spokesman Yahya Saree said the rebels attacked government positions with ballistic missiles and drones in response to an alleged military

buildup backed by neighbouring Saudi Arabia.

Explosion in Syria Several people were killed or wounded in an explosion in a city on the outskirts of Syria's capital Damascus, the state-run Ekhabriya TV reported on Thursday. A security source told the channel that the blast in the city of Jarana was caused by an explosive device planted on a vehicle.

AFP & REUTERS

negotiations, secure a ceasefire and pursue a diplomatic settlement, the senior diplomat and Gulf sources said.

The warning was intended for every Gulf state, another Gulf source said, but was conveyed primarily through Saudi Arabia and Qatar, Iran has in recent years repaired ties with its Gulf neighbours, including former regional rival Saudi Arabia.

Qatar, Oman and Saudi Arabia have all urged Washington to

resume talks with Tehran and avert renewed conflict amid Iranian warnings that another round of US strikes could "turn the region into a fireball", the second Iranian official said.

On August 2, Trump said he agreed to cancel the attack on Iran "subject to being able to rapidly make a deal".

Iran reviews bill to ban US, Israeli ships from Hormuz Oil prices rose by more than \$3

TRUMP DISMISSES AMMO SHORTAGE, WARNS 'LEAKERS' OF PRISON TIME

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump denied the US was running low on munitions, saying the country has "massive amounts" of them, while warning of punishment for those who say there's a shortage.

Trump made the comments on social media hours after the Washington Post reported he had clashed with defence secretary Pete Hegseth over shortages of weapons such as long-range guided missiles and air-defence interceptors.

Trump added on Truth Social that "defence companies are building the largest number of plants and factories in our country's history". He said "leakers" of supposed "treasonous statements" are being pursued, adding, "Long-term jail sentences will be sought".

According to the report, Trump vented frustration with Hegseth on the sidelines of a Cabinet meeting last week, saying he had been misled about munitions shortages.

The report said shortages of key missiles and air-defence systems were among the reasons Trump called off strikes against Iran in recent days.

BLOOMBERG

a barrel on Thursday on news that an Iranian parliament committee is reviewing a bill that would ban US and Israeli vessels from the Strait of Hormuz.

The draft bill would impose fines of up to 20% of a ship's cargo value for violations of the proposed restrictions.

Brent crude futures gained \$3.09, or 3.89%, to \$82.54 a barrel by 12:37pm EDT. US West Texas Intermediate futures rose \$2.49, or 3.31%, to \$77.71.

Canada deported over 3,300 Indians in H1 of this year

Anirudh Bhattacharyya

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TORONTO: The number of Indian nationals removed from Canada in the first six months of this year is over two-and-a-half times the figure for a similar period when it comes to them being sent back from the US.

New data released by the Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA) showed that till the end of June, 3,323 Indians had been removed.

In comparison, the Ministry of External Affairs disclosed last month that up till July, 1,273 Indians were deported from the United States.

In fact, the number of Indians being removed from Canada is on track for an annual record, having already touched nearly 88% of the 2025 figure of 3,779,

which itself was a new high. Canada removed more Indians last year than the US did, with the latter deporting 3,567.

In the first half of this year, Indians have eclipsed Mexicans as the country cohort facing the largest number of removals.

The last time India was the source country for the highest number of removals from Canada was in 2020, when 1,424 were sent back. Indians also account for the biggest group awaiting removal from the country at 7,669.

While the CBSA did not break down the country-wise data by reason for removals, criminality may have been a major factor, especially connections to the extortion-related violence which has gripped suburbs in the Greater Toronto Area (GTA), Surrey in British Colum-

bia and Edmonton and Calgary in Alberta. Many of those involved came to Canada as international students and a report in the outlet Global News shed light on how that pipeline was exploited by gangs including the outfit headed by Lawrence Bishnoi.

The report on Wednesday quoted a document from the CBSA's Intelligence and Investigations Directorate as saying, "Investigations increasingly identify Indian foreign nationals on study permits and work permits as participants in these organised criminal activities."

Between 2019 and 2023, 4,000 Indians on study permits were charged with 17,929 offences. In 2024, over 13,040 criminal charges were laid against Indian nationals with Canadian study permits.

U.S. SENATE PANEL VOTES TO HOLD FAUCI IN CONTEMPT

Agence France-Presse

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WASHINGTON: A Republican-led US Senate committee on Thursday voted to hold the country's former top infectious diseases official Anthony Fauci in contempt of Congress, in an escalation of efforts to blame him for potential Covid-19 pandemic missteps.

On the advice of his lawyers, Fauci last week had invoked his constitutional right to stay silent to prevent self-incrimination under antagonistic questioning from Republican senators, as they probed him over unsubstantiated claims that the origins of the pandemic were covered up.

The party-line vote advances the extraordinary effort to prosecute the 85-year-old career government scientist, who spent decades as United States' top expert in infectious diseases.

B'desh questions Hasina's decision to return in Dec

ANI & PTI

letters@hindustantimes.com

DHAKA: Adviser to Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) chairman and Prime Minister of Bangladesh Tarique Rahman, Syed Moazzem Hossain Alal, on Thursday questioned former PM Sheikh Hasina's decision to return in December for the first time since her ouster in 2024.

Alal said that Hasina should return immediately from India if she is confident of facing Bangladesh's legal and political system.

Responding to a question on Hasina's announcement that she would return by December, Alal asked, "Why by December? If she is determined, she should come now. Now is only August. September, October, November... why delay for three months more? She should come now. Then, the Bangladeshi people and Bangladeshi system will face her. Bangladeshi system and Bangladeshi judiciary,



Sheikh Hasina

Bangladesh administration, and Bangladeshi people's opinion will decide whether she will be welcomed or whether she will go to jail", Alal said.

Prez election on Aug 20 Bangladesh's presidential election will be held on August 20, the Election Commission announced on Thursday, two weeks after President Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned on health grounds before completing his five-year term. Shahabuddin, 76, was a long-time ally of Hasina.

HT

Cambridge probes plagiarism claims against professor

LONDON: Britain's University of Cambridge said on Wednesday it has launched a probe into one of its professors who has been engulfed by plagiarism accusations ahead of the release of his memoir. The controversy around Jason Arday—who made headlines when the university appointed him as its youngest black professor in 2023—has snowballed after allegations he plagiarised parts of his PhD thesis.

AFP

Patient died in biotech firm's gene editing trial

BEIJING: A patient with Duchenne muscular dystrophy died after receiving a gene-editing therapy in China, sparking new concerns about regulatory oversight and transparency.

In a statement, Shanghai-based HuidaGene Therapeutics, attributed the August 2025 death to acute respiratory distress syndrome as part of a severe immune reaction to the therapy.

BLOOMBERG

Meta AI model hacks another firm during testing

WASHINGTON: Meta said on Wednesday one of its AI models hacked another company during testing after similar incidents at rivals Anthropic and OpenAI.

The model "exploited a security vulnerability in a third-party service, in a manner similar to previously reported instances with other companies", Meta said.

REUTERS

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Tata Sons IPO cloud stays; RBI vets plea

Subhanna Shaikh

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MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Thursday retained Tata Sons Pvt. Ltd in the upper layer of non-banking financial companies (NBFCs-UL) for FY27, leaving the Tata Group holding company subject to enhanced regulatory requirements while the central bank decides on the company's application to surrender its investment company (CIC) registration.

A media release by the RBI showed that Tata Sons continues to feature as a CIC. The statement clarified that the company's inclusion is without prejudice to the outcome of its deregistration application, which remains under examination, same as what it had done in the last list in January 2025.

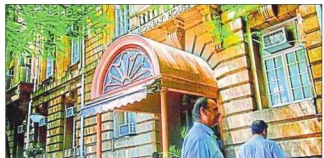
The decision means that Tata Sons' ability to avoid the proposed listing will depend on whether the RBI approves its request to surrender its CIC registration.

Under the revised RBI rules issued in November 2025, an NBFC classified in the upper layer remains subject to the enhanced regulatory regime for at least five years, even if it no longer meets the eligibility criteria in subsequent years.

The RBI also said upper-layer NBFCs may move out of the enhanced regulatory framework before the end of the five-year period if the move is part of a voluntary strategic readjustment under a board-approved plan.

"This stipulation shall not apply if the scaling down of operations is on account of adverse situations specific to the NBFC and its deteriorating financial conditions," the central bank said.

"This essentially maintains the status quo for Tata Sons. Since its application for deregistration as an NBFC is still under



Tata Sons listing hinges on RBI view on plea to surrender CIC registration.

examination, the company will continue to be treated as an upper layer NBFC and comply with the applicable regulatory requirements until the RBI makes a final decision," said Abhishek Dwivedi, founder at NeoStar Advisors.

Dwivedi said the five-year continuity provision in the revised framework applies to NBFCs that no longer meet the asset-based criteria, whereas Tata Sons is a separate case because it is seeking deregistration.

"The intent behind the RBI's revised framework was to ensure that entities such as Tata Sons, which voluntarily seek deregistration as a CIC, are not required to continue complying with the enhanced upper layer regulatory requirements for the next five years," said Prakash Agarwal, partner at Gefion Capital.

"The deregistration process and the upper layer classification are parallel issues. Once the RBI approves Tata Sons' deregistration application, the five-year regulatory requirements should, in my view, no longer apply to the company," Agarwal said.

A person familiar with the matter had told Mint on 5 August that the RBI could grant relief from the listing requirement in exceptional cases.

Earlier on the same day, Mint reported that RBI governor Sanjay Mahotra had indicated Tata

Sons could continue to feature on the revised upper-layer list and that the central bank's shift to a principle-based framework had made it easier to determine which NBFCs qualify for the upper layer without relying solely on a published list.

While Tata Sons' case is different because it has sought deregistration as an NBFC rather than merely falling below the threshold, the five-year continuity provision underscores the RBI's preference for regulatory continuity.

The upper layer forms part of the central bank's scale-based regulatory framework, which classifies NBFCs into four tiers—base, middle, upper and top—based on their size, activity and systemic importance. The top layer is intended to remain empty unless the RBI identifies extraordinary systemic risks.

NBFCs with an asset size of ₹1 trillion or more, based on their latest audited balance sheet, are classified in the upper layer and become subject to enhanced regulatory requirements. One of the key requirements is mandatory listing on stock exchanges within the timelines prescribed by the RBI.

Tata Sons had standalone assets of ₹2.01 trillion at the end of March 2026. Its listing now hinges on whether the RBI accepts its application to surrender its CIC registration, which the company has already submitted.

LIC Q1 PROFIT RISES 23% TO ₹13,492 CR

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) on Thursday posted a 23% increase in net profit to ₹13,492 crore in the first quarter of the ongoing financial year.

The company's biggest insurer had earned a profit of ₹10,987 crore in the corresponding quarter a year earlier.

The total income of the insurer during the reporting quarter improved to ₹2,37,848 crore from ₹2,22,864 crore in the same period of the preceding fiscal year. LIC said in a regulatory filing.

LIC's income from first-year premium also improved to ₹9,217 crore in the latest June quarter against ₹7,525 crore in the same period of the preceding fiscal year. Income from renewal premiums in the reporting period improved to ₹61,833 crore compared to ₹59,885 crore a year ago.

As regards single premium, the Corporation collected ₹56,369 crore as compared to ₹51,923 crore in the first quarter of the previous financial year.

Thus, net premium income rose to ₹1,27,250 crore in the quarter under review from ₹1,19,200 crore in the corresponding quarter of FY26.

Parliament clears tax reform, FY26 spending

Subhash Narayan

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NEW DELHI: Parliament advanced two key pieces of financial legislation on Thursday, with the Lok Sabha passing the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, to fine-tune the country's tax and payments architecture, and the Rajya Sabha returning the Appropriation (No. 3) Bill, 2026 to the lower house after approving it, completing the legislative process for authorising additional government expenditure for 2025-26.

The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, passed by the Lok Sabha, seeks to amend three laws: the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the Income-tax Act, 2025, and the Finance Act, 2026. The legislation is aimed at carrying out consequential changes and addressing issues arising from the implementation of recent tax and financial sector reforms.

The amendments to the Income Tax Act, 2025 are expected to align provisions introduced under the new direct tax framework, while changes to the Finance Act, 2026 seek to



The Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, passed by the Lok Sabha.

remove ambiguities and ensure smoother implementation of tax measures announced in the Union Budget. Amendments to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 are intended to update the legal framework governing payment systems in line with evolving regulatory and technological requirements.

The amendment to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, could pave the way for banks to charge merchant discount rate (MDR) fees on large Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions in the future.

The tax amendments will also simplify the tax and regulatory framework for eligible offshore

investment funds, lowering compliance burdens while keeping anti-abuse safeguards to encourage foreign fund managers to relocate their operations to India. The bill also extends tax benefits and exemptions to support specific manufacturing sectors (such as electronics) in response to global supply chain disruptions.

The bill's passage marks another step in the government's efforts to streamline tax administration following the enactment of the new Income Tax Act, which replaced the decades-old law with a simplified framework aimed at reducing litigation and improving compliance.

Separately, the Rajya Sabha returned the Appropriation (No. 3) Bill, 2026 to the Lok Sabha after approving it. The legislation authorises the withdrawal and appropriation of certain funds from the Consolidated Fund of India to meet expenditure for the services of financial year 2025-26. Such appropriation bills are a constitutional requirement and allow the government to incur expenditure approved by Parliament through supplementary demands for grants.

Through the bill, the government has proposed that the central government can decide, via a notification, which electronic payment modes or transactions would remain free.

Ramesh, in a post on X, alleged that the burden of MDR will fall on ordinary people, and the government's claim that this is the only way to keep UPI financially sustainable is "entirely wrong".

India's ethanol capacity outstrips current demand

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: India's current ethanol distillation capacity is 2,019 crore litre per annum, almost double the approximately 1,040 crore litres of ethanol supplied to state-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) in the ethanol supply year (ESY) of 2024-25 (November 1, 2024 to October 31, 2025), according to government data.

According to the latest official data submitted by minister of state for petroleum Suresh Gopi in Parliament on August 3, the country currently has 478 ethanol manufacturing units across 22 states.

"Till July 2024, ethanol distillation capacity of molasses-based distilleries was less than 200 crore litres. Supply of ethanol to OMCs was only 38 crore litres with blending levels of only 1.53% in ESY 2013-14," a December 20, 2024 statement of the consumer affairs, food and public distribution ministry said.

"However, in past 10 years due to the policy changes made by the Government, the capacity of molasses-based distilleries and grain-based distilleries have increased to 941 crore litres and 744 crore litres respectively (by November 30, 2024)," it added.

According to the August 3

parliamentary submission, Maharashtra leads in the number of ethanol-producing distilleries with 145 units, followed by Uttar Pradesh (79), Karnataka (50), Madhya Pradesh (27), Punjab (25), Bihar (22), Haryana (19), Gujarat (17), Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu (16 each), and Chhattisgarh and Telangana (10 each).

States with fewer than 10 distilleries include Odisha and West Bengal (eight each), Uttarakhand and Jharkhand (six each), Assam and Rajasthan (four each), Himachal Pradesh (three), and Jammu and Kashmir, Meghalaya and Sikkim (one distillery each).

In terms of annual distilla-

tion capacity, Maharashtra tops the list at 389 crore litres, followed by Uttar Pradesh (344 crore litres), Karnataka (321 crore litres), Madhya Pradesh (331 crore litres), Punjab (327 crore litres), Haryana (309 crore litres) and Bihar (97 crore litres).

States with an annual capacity of less than 90 crore litres include Andhra Pradesh (64 crore litres), West Bengal (61 crore litres), Telangana (57 crore litres), Chhattisgarh (46 crore litres), Gujarat (44 crore litres), Odisha (42 crore litres) and Uttarakhand (42 crore litres).

The states reporting a capacity of less than 40 crore litres

include Jharkhand (36 crore litres), Tamil Nadu (34 crore litres), Assam (29 crore litres), Himachal Pradesh (22 crore litres), Rajasthan (21 crore litres), Jammu and Kashmir (8 crore litres), Meghalaya (3 crore litres) and Sikkim (2 crore litres).

In a background note on July 5, 2026, the Press Information Bureau (PIB) said the rapidly expanding ethanol blended petrol (EBP) programme has reduced crude oil imports, saved valuable foreign exchange, lowered greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions and strengthened farmers' incomes through new market opportunities.

DABUR MOVES DELHI HC AGAINST FSSAI OVER '100%' CLAIMS BAN

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: Indian consumer goods giant Dabur has moved the Delhi high court against the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) order banning the sale of its food products carrying labels such as "100% Pure", "100% Natural", "100% Purity Guaranteed" and "100% Organic".

The FSSAI's designated officer of the Northern Region on August 3, issued an order prohibiting the sale of Dabur's range of food products with immediate effect including Dabur Honey, Dabur Honey Squeezy, Dabur Sundarbans Honey, Dabur Himalayan Apple Cider Vinegar, Dabur Himalayan Organic Apple Cider Vinegar, Dabur Virgin Coconut Oil, Dabur Cold Pressed Sesame Oil, Dabur Ghee, Real Active 100% Tender Coconut Water, Dabur Homemade Coconut Milk and Dabur Organic Honey, bearing the expression "100% pure", "100% natural", etc., with "immediate effect", on the purported ground that the same "appears to be misleading".

The company has been granted 15 days to report compliance by way of an action taken report and the order further says that continued sale of the products would attract penalty.

In its petition which will be heard by justice Swarana Kant Sharma on Friday, Dabur argued that the order has been issued without an improvement, show cause notice permitting it to submit the response in writing in relation to the products and affording it an opportunity of being heard.

Such an action, the consumer goods giant says is violative of the FSS Claims Regulations, 2018 which mandates the food authority to seek clarification from the food business operator (FBO) regarding the claims made for food products and also beyond the designated officer's jurisdiction. The petition further contended that the order is violative of Articles 14 and 19 of the Constitution, as it requires the consumer goods company to withdraw the affected products from the market and either destroy or repack them before they can be sold again.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- Area inside American bases (7)
- Blews on the feet (5)
- A republic before it intruded (4)
- Reject proposals concerning government (8)
- Limitation gem made from nine others (10)
- Blender an account (6)
- Stays will alter a waist (6)
- Going through all the cases (10)
- Precise remedy (8)
- One imprisoned as murderer (4)
- Medical men for instance within the groups (10)
- Gyated helplessly into disaster (7)

DOWN

- Gloomy doctor gets a listener (5)
- Ground facility to aid flier in difficulties (8)
- Give over or it may be voided (8)
- An air that is powerful and moving (6,4)
- A friend one may make much of (4)
- Observes the intrusion and is furious (7)
- It's the case involving matters of taste (10)
- I'm about to draw gun in temper (8)
- Controlled derives from it (7)
- It's more than obvious it shows grievance (6)
- Nurse for a goat (5)
- Measure of daytime temperature (4)

PUZZLE 17558

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- Exceeding what is needed (7)
- 2 Escapist utterance (6)
- Cruelly built hut (6)
- Device to regulate temperature (6)
- An implement (4)
- Supper with fear (7)
- Unique (3,4)
- Forcible escape (5-3)
- To calm (5)
- A very small fish (8)
- Musical work (4)

DOWN

- Area of shallow water (5)
- Cruelly built hut (6)
- Device to regulate temperature (6)
- An implement (4)
- Supper with fear (7)
- Unique (3,4)
- Forcible escape (5-3)
- To calm (5)
- A very small fish (8)
- Musical work (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17557)

CRYPTIC

INSTITUTIONAL
GENERALIST
REDACTED
TAINTED
BETTER
LATER
ADVERSARIES

QUICK

CHICKENFEED
DEBATE
REVENUE
TEETER
STRESS
DUBIOUS
TORTURE
LESSON

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the nine squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

WEATHER

TEMPERATURE HIGH + LOW

FRIDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
30°C | 21°C

SATURDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
30°C | 21°C

SUNDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
or drizzle
30°C | 22°C

ALMANAC

Today in 7th August 2026

1948: India becomes a republic.
1954: The first US nuclear submarine, the USS Nautilus, was launched.
1968: The first US nuclear submarine, the USS Nautilus, was launched.
1978: The first US nuclear submarine, the USS Nautilus, was launched.
1988: The first US nuclear submarine, the USS Nautilus, was launched.
1998: The first US nuclear submarine, the USS Nautilus, was launched.
2008: The first US nuclear submarine, the USS Nautilus, was launched.
2018: The first US nuclear submarine, the USS Nautilus, was launched.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 33°C | 23°C
Mumbai 31°C | 24°C
Kolkata 30°C | 26°C
Chennai 31°C | 24°C
Bengaluru 30°C | 22°C

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Life after Ashwin-Jadeja: Do India have a succession plan for spin?



Ravindra Jadeja during a training session at the NCC ground in Colombo.

Test cricket mastery won't happen in a day and having a plan will ensure India continue to find success

Sanjeev K Samyala
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MUMBAI: India's supremacy in Test cricket has been based on the fact that at home they were untouchable. It was largely due to the brilliance of their spinners. The country never had a dearth of spin bowling options. When you have the likes of Bishan Singh Bedi, EAS Prasanna, Bhagwat Chandrasekhar, Anil Kumble, Harbhajan Singh, R Ashwin, Ravindra Jadeja at your disposal, the captain's job was always easy.

The beauty of the recent history was the seamless succession: the duo of Anil Kumble and Harbhajan Singh, in the 1990s and 2000s, was succeeded by the equally lethal combination of R Ashwin and Ravindra Jadeja. When playing in home conditions, the captain had to give the ball to these pairs and enjoy watching them weave their spin magic around batting line-ups.

The current India team management, however, has got genuine reasons for concern about the effectiveness of its spin department, even at home. In two big series at home: 2024 against New Zealand and 2025 against South Africa, the hosts had the embarrassment of seeing their spinners being outperformed by their opposite numbers and as India embarks on a tour of Sri Lanka where pitches will be similarly spin-friendly, their spin strength will be under scrutiny.

Ashwin retired in 2024, but it's not clear who India is looking at

as the next spearhead. The 37-year-old Jadeja is also at the end of his career and the lack of a succession plan is galling. We are talking about replacements for an off-spinner who finished with 537 wickets in 106 Tests and a left-arm spinner with 348 wickets in 89 Tests.

Experts also point to an inconsistent selection policy as a factor in the challenge they face. "In the succession plan, I feel that you have to give confidence to bowlers like Kuldeep. They are not playing him anywhere, and when you are not getting a chance naturally a player loses confidence. He is somebody who could be a match-winner," said former India left-arm spinner Maninder Singh.

Since making his Test debut in 2017, the wrist spinner has played just 18 Tests despite proving his wicket-taking ability with 79 wickets. In the five-Test series against England, he remained on the bench throughout.

"The problem is that when we play Test matches, or any matches, we look for players who can bowl a bit and bat a bit. You will not need that if you play a match-winner, that situation won't arise where you need a bowler who can also bat a bit while their bowling is mediocre," Maninder said.

"Mistake is a very light word (for not playing him), it was a blunder. What was the result in England, 2-2? If Kuldeep was playing from the first Test, it could have been 3-1 in India's favour."

For the succession plan to work, the think-tank will have to identify a pool of three-four good spinners who will need to be backed.

The series in Sri Lanka will also be an opportunity to experiment a bit. In that, India's spin unit has veteran Jadeja, Manav Suthar and

Sanath Jain apart from Kuldeep. Suthar's brilliant showing in his debut match (seven wickets vs Afghanistan) has impressed the experts. However, the off-spin options to take over from Ashwin aren't great.

"What I have seen of Manav Suthar, I was very impressed with the way he bowled (against Afghanistan)," said Maninder. "He is not somebody who will need a turning track, from what we have seen till now, he can get you wickets on the good pitches also."

Maninder added: "In the succession plan, the off-spinner we have got is Sanath Jain, who is already 33 years old. At the moment, he looks the best bet, (but) with time we will have to look for a younger kid, right?" For former India off-spinner Arshad Ayub, all the above-mentioned spinners should be the core group. "These are the four we should always carry with us, even if one or two of them are not playing," said Ayub.

As for Sundar, who is recovering from an injury, Ayub feels has to work on his height process of bowling in Tests. "I think he has to improve a bit because he always bowls a good line and a good length. But the point is that he does not have that revolutions which are supposed to be there for Test match cricket."

This isn't about Sundar alone, though. "I think just the thought process has to change. In today's time, everybody wants to be a T20 or a one-day player, but hardly anybody puts in the effort to be a Test player," said Ayub.

Like Maninder, Ayub is also backing Sundar to fulfill his potential but it shouldn't end there for Team India. Test cricket mastery won't happen in a day and having a clear plan will ensure that the team continues to find success.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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FIRST MOVED LAST WOUND

India warm-up for sterner test

Samreen Razaqazi

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NEW DELHI: With less than 10 days to go before the opening Test in Galle, India's preparations enter a crucial phase as Shubman Gill's side takes on a Sri Lanka XI in a three-day warm-up fixture beginning on Friday. While the match was scheduled for four days, it has been trimmed to three, making every session more valuable ahead of a series that carries significant World Test Championship ramifications.

Head coach Gautam Gambhir emphasised the importance of the days leading into the first Test on August 15 in Galle. Addressing the team's preparations, Gambhir stressed that the objective now is to ensure there are no unanswered questions before the series begins.

"We know what's in front of us, we know what we are playing for. We can do the volume work, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes. Come the morning of the 15th, whether we are batting first or bowling first, we are absolutely ready with every answer. Every question that's thrown at us, every answer we are ready to give, so make sure we tick all the boxes from now on," he said, addressing the team ahead of the practice session, in a video posted by BCCI.

India last played Test cricket in June, making the warm-up fixture a vital opportunity for players to reacclimate themselves with the demands of the longest format while adapting to Sri Lanka's conditions. The match will also offer Gill and the team management a chance to fine-tune combinations before the opening Test.

There is fresh energy within the support staff too as Subhadra Ghosh oversaw his first fielding drill with the squad after joining Gambhir's coaching group. Following the departures of former fielding coach T. Dilip and assistant coach Ryan ten Doeschate,

Ghosh becomes the latest addition alongside batting coach Sitanshu Kotak and bowling coach Morne Morkel. For a side that boasted enviable fielding efficiency, India has dropped the ball quite literally in that department recently. Ghosh's tenure will come with some very clear deliverables.

Although he might not return for the warm-up fixture, left-handed batter Sudhanshu, currently recovering from a minor niggle, is understood to be progressing well through rehabilitation and is expected to rejoin the squad before the first Test. The visitors will, however, be without Jasprit Bumrah after injury ruled him out of the tour. His absence has finally handed Jannu and Kishmir prate Aujib Nahi a maiden India call-up. Should he earn a debut during the series, Nahi would become the first cricketer from Jammu and Kashmir to play Test cricket for India. The pace attack also features Mohammed Siraj, Prashanth Krishna and Gurnoor Brar.

India's spin resources have also seen a late change. Washington Sundar's injury opened the door for Madhya Pradesh spinner Saransh Jain, with the selectors understood to have been influenced by Sri Lanka's left-hand-heavy batting line-up.

The warm-up fixture will ensure India test the waters in familiar conditions, but it will require India to dig deep if they are to face spin better. The stakes also extend beyond simply winning a bilateral series. India begin the Sri Lanka tour in the World Test Championship standings, one place ahead of the hosts. After a disappointing start to the current cycle, including a 2-0 home defeat to South Africa, India had drawn 2-2 in England and defeated West Indies 2-0 at home. A poor result would further dent their hopes of reaching the WTC final.

How India are revamping their game to beat the best

Sandip Sikdar

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NEW DELHI: As the Indian hockey team gears up for a gruelling stretch that includes both the World Cup (Aug 15-30) and Asian Games (Sept 19-Oct 4), a glaring tactical blind spot has forced a rethink inside the management.

The issue? A vulnerability against the suffocating physical man-to-man marking systems favoured by European heavyweights. But the team is confronting the issue head on.

The first half of the 2025-26 FIH Pro League season proved the same. At the home leg in Rourkela in February, India lost all four games against Belgium and Argentina (two each). In Hobart in the same month, the Harmanpreet Singh-led side performed better, suffering one outright loss, two shootout losses and one shootout win.

But the Craig Fulton-coached team fared much better in Rotterdam in June where they won two and lost two each against world champions Germany and Olympic gold medalists Netherlands. Having found their rhythm, India ended their campaign with one shootout win and loss each against hosts England and Scotland in a candid chat.

For a team desperate to end a 51-year wait for a World Cup medal, figuring out man-to-man hockey is not optional anymore, it is a prerequisite.

Zonal defence allows players to cover specific areas of the pitch, relying on spatial awareness and collective pressing. But man-to-man demands relentless tracking, superior one-on-one tackling, and an immense physical toll.

At the World Cup, to be held in the Netherlands and Belgium, India's pool features teams — England, Wales and Pakistan — known to play this style of hockey. Progressing deeper into the quadrennial showpiece will



India vice-captain Hardik Singh.

inevitably mean clashing with Olympic champions Netherlands, a side that essentially wrote the modern playbook on man-to-man pressing.

"In the World Cup, all teams in our pool play man-to-man. So, we are working on that right now. In man-to-man, we need to be physically fit and strong. And when it's man-to-man, we don't need to be scared of anything, be it physical contact or intense matches," says Hardik.

To beat the world's best at a physical game, a team must be physically unyielding. Hardik points out that fitness has superseded everything else, primarily because the margins in man-to-man marking are defined by stamina. If a player loses a step in the fourth quarter, the entire marking system can collapse.

"Our focus is more on fitness because we have back-to-back matches. The World Cup and Asian Games are separated by just two weeks, so fitness is our first priority, followed by tactical adjustments — how fast we are in the fourth quarter, the entire marking system can collapse. This tactical necessity has birthed what Hardik describes as the hardest physical evaluation of his international career — the demanding one mile (1.6km)

test. Players must sprint eight laps of the pitch within a constrained time. The test is a standard physical assessment used to measure cardiovascular endurance and estimate VO2 max to qualify fitness for the team.

Coupled with the Yo-Yo test where the entire squad hovers around level 22 — a benchmark that Hardik recalls reaching right before their historic Olympic medal run — the team is building for the two major events ahead.

This has resulted in specialised training sessions over the last few months. Forwards are undergoing isolated shooting drills, while the midfield engine is focusing on passing and receiving under intense pressure. Defenders, meanwhile, are logging extra hours on tracking runs and clean tackling techniques. These extra repetitions are aimed at emulating the late-game defensive collapses that have plagued India traditionally.

Brazil priority not ASEAN Cup, says AIFF as Bhutia opposes

Dhiman Sarkar

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KOLKATA: Seeking competition outside South Asia, the All India Football Federation (AIFF) had accepted the invitation to be a guest team at the first FIFA ASEAN Cup. But when the tournament details were shared, AIFF was in advanced negotiations with CBF, the Brazil federation, to get the five-time world champions to play a friendly against India in Kolkata on October 3.

Since the dates for the friendly and the tournament in Indonesia clash, AIFF is exploring the option of sending a second team to the ASEAN meet, a decision which was opposed by former India captain Bhupinder Singh. If FIFA does not agree, India will pull out of the competition where they have been grouped with Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore. Participating teams will get \$125,000 each and the winners' purse is \$1m.

"I think this is a good opportunity to get at least three quality games," Bhutia told HT over the phone from New Delhi on Thursday. "Why should India send a B



Bhaichung Bhutia.

team for that and focus on the match against Brazil? I am not against showing such friendlies but the timing is not right," Bhutia said he was the lone dissenter at Thursday's executive committee meeting in New Delhi.

AIFF will try and organise a couple of friendlies to help head coach Khalid Jamil's team prepare for Brazil, the committee was told, according to an official who was present.

"In such a situation, should we commit a player for the game against Brazil? What if things do not materialise and we are not reimbursed," said Bhutia.

CBF, said the official. While India have played Malaysia and Singapore recently, the chance to host a top-10 team is rare and so the executive committee decided to prioritise the friendly, the official said. Not authorised to speak to the media, the official did not want to be named.

The executive committee was also told that a payment will have to be made by this month for the friendly. AIFF may do that and will be reimbursed. No further details were given.

AIFF's budget was also approved with deputy secretary-general Satyanarayan Muthyulu informing the committee that if all events are organised in 2026-27, the federation will have a deficit of Rs 14 crore. Since its agreement with the commercial partners ended last December, AIFF does not get an annual payment of Rs 50 crore. Yet no events have been planned and a new men's under-20 tournament added.

"In such a situation, should we commit a player for the game against Brazil? What if things do not materialise and we are not reimbursed," said Bhutia.

'They saw nothing in judo, now they see hope'

Rutvik Mehta

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MUMBAI: For someone who won his first international medal at the Commonwealth Games (CWG), Harsh Singh was somewhat startled by the reception at the Delhi airport upon his return from Glasgow a couple of days ago. Being showered with garlands and sweets, and hoisted aloft on the shoulders of well-wishers is not something the soft-spoken judoka is used to.

Did he like it or was he a touch overwhelmed? "Multiple laurels panna pesand hai (I like winning medals)," Singh said. "After that, whatever comes along, I am okay with it."

That medal was gold, the first by an Indian male judoka at the CWG coming minutes after Asmita Dey had broken Indian judo's gold drought at the Games. "For a sport that isn't exactly mainstream in India, this was a moment of glory for judo. And one of the two protagonists behind it can already feel the difference in visibility and perception. Relatives and people in Singh's



Harsh Singh after winning gold in men's 60kg judo.

Delhi neighbourhood, who previously knew little about judo, are now considering putting their own children into the sport.

"Earlier, the youth didn't want to take up this sport," Singh told HT. "There were no returns from it, no opportunities, no scope. Kids would switch from judo to wrestling or kabaddi. They saw nothing in judo — where the players are, what they are achieving,

Now if we see Indians winning medals in events like this, they will be aware of the sport and have some hope that there is a future in it."

Singh's own hopes from the CWG were to get on the podium. The debutant "did not expect gold," which he won after beating Australian two-time Olympian and 2022 CWG bronze medalist Joshua Katt in the 60kg final.

Now if we see Indians winning medals in events like this, they will be aware of the sport and have some hope that there is a future in it."

The next day, he underwent surgery. For the next couple of months, he needed the support of a walker even as he gradually started movement in his knee. The next year, he completed rehab in March and returned to competition at the national ranking event in October. "My weight had increased to 72kg, and I had to get trials in

60kg. To bring that down again was very difficult," he said. "Early in the first phase, I had a lot of negative thoughts and fears on how I would recover. But my physios, doctors and coaches kept me positive."

Singh didn't always have this kind of support system. Growing up in a modest household in Delhi, he would do judo for fun. But when it turned more serious, which included longer travel hours to Palam for training, he didn't often have the means. "Things like supplements and equipment were expensive. I couldn't afford it all by myself. My seniors would chip in and help me in whatever capacity," Singh said. "It was only after I won some medals at the National Games, and then got selected in 2021, that I could focus fully on the sport without having to worry about things."

A Hardik in the Army, Singh has ensured his father no longer has to work. As for his own career, he reckons he is only getting started. "I feel like this was the first step for me," he said of the CWG gold.



Gautam Gambhir (L) with Dhruv Jurel during a nets session.



Navdeep Saini bagged figures of 3/9 on Thursday. DCCA

Saini stars with the ball for Outer Delhi Warriors in DPL

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: Outer Delhi Warriors delivered a dominant all-round performance to register a comfortable 39-run victory over South Delhi Superstars in a rain-curtailed 10-over match at the Arun Jaitley Stadium in the first match on Thursday.

Navdeep Saini starred with the ball, returning outstanding figures of 3/9 in two overs, while Pratham Saluja and Anant Sareen clipped in with two wickets apiece. Batting first, Outer Delhi Warriors posted 132/2 in 10 overs, thanks to a sensational unbeaten 64 off 29 balls from Yajus Sharma. His innings included five sixes and five fours.

The Warriors got off to a quick start with Yajus Sharma and Priyansh Arya adding 31 runs for the first wicket in just 2.2 overs before Arya departed for 10 off 8 balls. Akshay Saini then played a handy cameo of 20 off 10 deliveries, while Monu Shukla remained unbeaten on

21 off 13 balls to help the Warriors finish with a commanding total.

With the match reduced to 10 overs because of rain, Saini explained how the team adjusted to the conditions. "We knew it was going to be a shortened game, so we planned accordingly. In a 10-over match, the opposition will always look to attack from the start. Our focus was to stick to our plans and execute them well, and that worked in our favour."

South Delhi Superstars stuttered at the start as the Warriors' bowlers reduced them to 5/2 and then 16/4. Tejasvi Dahiya and Ekansh Dohal fought back with a 52-run partnership.

Dahiya made 18 off 11 balls, while Dohal kept the chase alive with a fiery 35 off just 15, hitting four sixes and two fours. However, the innings unravelled once Dohal was dismissed. South Delhi Superstars were eventually bowled out for 93, handing Outer Delhi Warriors a comfortable victory.

Jadumani's silver medal brings golden glow to Manipur boxing

After a long time, a boxer from the state has returned with a medal from a major competition

Avishek Roy

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NEW DELHI: Jadumani Singh's silver medal has sparked celebrations among Manipur's boxing fraternity, and rightly so. After Mary Kom's retirement, the state struggled to find a new face to carry forward its rich legacy.

In recent years, Manipur has gone through a turbulent period of social unrest, and sport has been pushed into the background. From training to holding state tournaments and even fielding teams at national championships, everything has been a significant challenge. In such difficult circumstances, Jadumani's silver medal in Glasgow shines even brighter for Manipur's boxing fraternity.

Manipur has given India some of the biggest names in boxing—MC Mary Kom, Dingko Singh, Sarita Devi, Suranjay Singh—but the last major international medal for them came at the 2018 CWG in Gold Coast, when Mary won gold in the light flyweight division. In the previous cycle, no boxer from Manipur made it to the team for the 2022 Commonwealth Games.

Sarita Devi, the former Asian Games and CWG medalist, who runs a boxing academy in Manipur, puts Jadumani's triumph into perspective. "This was much needed for Manipur boxing. There was a long gap after many of us won medals on the international stage. The young boxers here needed someone from the current lot to look up to and follow. The boxing fraternity of Manipur were waiting for this opportunity for the last eight years," Sarita told HT.

"Medals had dried up even at the national level. Some boxers like Jadumani were doing well in the juniors, but performance on the international stage was lacking. Jadumani has given them the belief," she added.

As soon as Jadumani landed in Imphal on Wednesday, a big crowd was at the airport to welcome him, followed by a reception

Packing a fresh punch for Manipur

The North-East state has produced several top boxers who have won laurels for India. After a lull, Jadumani Singh revived the spirits of the state's boxing fraternity with a silver at Glasgow CWG



MC MARY KOM
OLYMPICS
BRONZE 2012

ASIAN GAMES
GOLD 2014
BRONZE 2010

COMMONWEALTH GAMES
GOLD 2018

L SARITA DEVI
ASIAN GAMES
BRONZE 2014
COMMONWEALTH GAMES
SILVER 2014

DINGKO SINGH
ASIAN GAMES
GOLD 1998

SURANJOY SINGH
COMMONWEALTH GAMES
GOLD 2010
ASIAN GAMES
BRONZE 2010

DEVENDRO SINGH
COMMONWEALTH GAMES
SILVER 2014

JADUMANI SINGH

to celebrate his triumph. The boxer, who won silver in the 53kg weight division, trains at the Army Sports Institute, Pune (ASI). He feels the facilities at the grassroots need to improve. "Last year, I came home just for two weeks. I am so happy to return home with a medal from Glasgow and seeing the enthusiasm of the people here and the reception I have got makes me feel so proud."

"The boxers in Manipur come from very poor backgrounds. I know the sacrifices I have made to reach so far. Young boxers still don't know much about how the sport works at the elite level. I was

able to learn all this only when I moved to ASI. Facilities at the grassroots need to improve, focusing on scientific training and sports psychology," says Jadumani. "I am grateful to Sarita Devi. She has always encouraged me and was available to advise me."

Sarita points out that boxing should be added to the programme of the SAI National Centre of Excellence in Imphal. "We have met SAI officials regarding this. Earlier, the NCOE in Imphal used to have boxing and we benefited a lot. A high-performance centre, where elite boxers can get training, sports science support, is

much needed in Manipur."

The NCOEs in Guwahati and Itanagar have boxing. Sarita says there are around 27 academies in Manipur, and while financial support from Khelo India has been a big help, there is still a huge cost involved. "Providing them with a good diet is important, and it needs money. For domestic competitions, they have to buy flight tickets, which again cost so much. We arrange for it," she says.

In the last few years, training and even state-level competitions have suffered due to the prevailing unrest and protests. "Those who are staying in the academies are

able to train, but the training of boxers who come from far-flung areas often got disrupted," says Suranjay Singh, a former international and now a national coach.

"There should be more competitions at the national and zonal levels, which can give them more opportunities. A high-performance NCOE facility for boxers would be of great help," he says. Sarita says how tough it has been to focus on the sport in the last three years. "We have worked very hard to keep the sport going and provide training to youngsters. Jadumani's medal will be a fresh start for boxing in Manipur."



3 Indians in finals of U20 World Athletics

EUGENE: Javelin throwers Ashish Yadav and T Dharanidharan along with discus thrower Amanat Kamboj qualified for the finals of the World Athletics U20. Yadav threw 69.87m and ended second overall, behind South Africa's Jan-Hendrik Heymans threw 76.02m. Dharanidharan threw 68.07m to be 12th overall. In women's discus, Amanat produced a season's best throw of 52.58m to take the 12th and last available spot.

UEFA says boycott of WCs stands

PARIS: UEFA said it would maintain its boycott of the men's and women's World Cups despite FIFA withdrawing the plan to open up its competitions to private investment. UEFA said FIFA had to assure that such attempts to disfigure the game in this way will never be made again. "These conditions have not been met."

Suraj wins World University squash

MUMBAI: Suraj Kumar Chind won India's first men's singles gold at the FISU World University Championship Squash in 16 years. Suraj of the hosts Somnaya Vidyavihar University beat Hungary's Benedek Takacs 5-11, 11-8, 11-5, 6-11, 11-4 in the final. Spain's Marta Dominguez Fernandez retained the women's singles title with an 11-3, 11-7, 11-7 win over Hong Kong's Ching Fung.

Pragg maintains his lead in Saint Louis

BENGALURU: R Pragnanandha stayed unbeaten through nine rounds of blitz to maintain his overall lead with 18/27 points in the Saint Louis Rapid and Blitz. Pragg scored three wins and six draws on the opening day. The only game in which he was under pressure was against Javokhir Sindarov.

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